

NORTHERN RAILWAY E-AUCTION NOTICE								
The Sr. Divisional Commercial Manager/G. Northern Railway, Delhi Division, New Delhi invites e-Auction through IREPS (https://ireps.gov.in/) for allotment of contracts of General Minor Units (GMUs) and Special Minor Units (SMUs) for Catering Units at following railway stations/locations:								
S.N.	Auction Catalogue No.	Date & Time for e-Auction	Railway Station	Lot No.	Type of Unit			
1	CTG-AUG-02-26	09.09.2026 at 11:00 Hrs	Samalkha	Catg-DLI-SMK-GMU-87-25-1	General Minor Unit (GMU)			
2			Okhla	Catg-DLI-OKA-GMU-170-25-1				
3			Tugalakabad	Catg-DLI-TKD-GMU-169-25-1				
4			Sampla	Catg-DLI-SPZ-GMU-150-25-1				
5				Catg-DLI-SPZ-GMU-149-25-1				
6			Mohiuddinpur	Catg-DLI-MUZ-GMU-154-25-1				
7			Mandawai Chander Vihar Halt	Catg-DLI-MWC-GMU-113-25-1				
8			Sujra Halt	Catg-DLI-SUJR-GMU-112-25-1				
9			Tilak Bridge	Catg-DLI-TKJ-GMU-111-25-1				
11			Taj Nagar	Catg-DLI-TNJR-GMU-176-25-1				
12			Patel Nagar	Catg-DLI-PTNR-GMU-142-25-1				
13			Sunehra	Catg-DLI-SFA-GMU-107-25-1				
14			Vivek Vihar	Catg-DLI-VVB-GMU-109-25-1				
15			Shahabad Markanda	Catg-DLI-SHDM-GMU-131-25-1				
16			Rathdhana	Catg-DLI-RDDE-GMU-155-25-1				
17			Muradnagar	Catg-DLI-MUD-GMU-91-25-1				
18				Catg-DLI-MUD-GMU-128-25-1				
19			Uchana	Catg-DLI-UCA-GMU-110-25-1				
20			Partapur	Catg-DLI-PRTPr-GMU-156-25-1				
21			Daya Basti	Catg-DLI-DBSI-SMU-116-25-1	Special Minor Unit (SMU)			
22			Delhi Azadpur	Catg-DLI-DAZ-SMU-122-25-1				
23			Palwal	Catg-DLI-PWL-SMU-166-25-1				
			Tuglakabad	Catg-DLI-TKD-SMU-117-25-1				
Website particulars where complete details of E-Auction can be seen			https://ireps.gov.in/ (E-Auction-Leasing)					
All contractors who intend to participate in the e-auctions conducted through E-Auction Leasing module of IREPS should fulfil following mandatory requirements before they can submit their bids: ➤ Registration on IREPS for E-Auction Leasing module – Active IREPS User Account for E-Auction Leasing Module. ➤ Payment of One Time Registration Fee; Current Account in State Bank of India; Integration of SBI Bank Account with IREPS Account; Lien Marking of Funds; Updation of Turnover Details. ➤ A new mechanism namely Virtual Account Number (VAN) has been introduced now for E-Auction Leasing module, which can be used by the bidders as an alternative to Lien Marking Mechanism. ➤ The bidders are free to switch between Lien Marking Mechanism (if activated) and VAN mechanism at any point of time, before entering the bidding room. VAN mechanism does not require the bidder to have a current account in State Bank of India. The users are free to transfer money from any of their existing bank accounts in any bank to their VAN account, which enables them to participate in IREPS E-Auctions. ➤ Contractors who do not have IREPS account for any module of IREPS can submit their online request for registration by clicking on New Vendors / Contractors (E-Tender / E-Auction Leasing) link on IREPS Home page.								
Railway Authority to Contact, in case of any query			Divisional Railway Manager's Office Commercial Branch, State Entry Road, New Delhi – 110055, Email: catering.delhidivision@gmail.com, Tel: 011-23743084					
No. 23 AC/Ctg./e-Auction/GMU & SMU/2026 Date: 24.08.2026					2945/2026			
SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE								

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi easily. A man on his knees at the edge of a filthy into the open drain that cuts through the neighbourhood.

through it all, and at some point, waiting became unbearable with the machinery of accountancy, arriving, as it point fingers at one another For Mithun's family

into the open drain that cuts through the neighbourhood. The drain is not a hidden hazard tucked away from public view. It runs openly through the middle of a residential colony, houses lining both banks, before it snakes on through Shaheen Bagh, empties into the Agra Canal, and eventually joins the Yamuna. Thousands walk past its edge every day. On that Saturday, it swallowed a child.

What followed was four days of searching that stretched a family's hope to breaking point. Fire tenders, then National Disaster Response Force teams, then divers and rescue personnel fanned out along the drain



when darkness made the water too dangerous to search. Morning after morning, it resumed, with no closer answer.

Awadhesh Kumar waited

top fingers at one another. For Mithun's family, migrants from Uttar Pradesh who came to Delhi to work as labourers, none of this restores what has been lost. A suspension order does not close an open drain that still runs, uncovered and ungarded, through a neighbourhood full of children. It does not explain why a drain known to carry a strong and dangerous flow was left without barriers in a residential lane. It only confirms what the family already knew in the water, in the garbage, in the four days of searching: that the city failed to protect their son long before anyone in office noticed.

₹2,990 crore had begun on 28 new decentralised sewerage treatment plants, with orders already issued, alongside ₹1,090 crore worth of upgrades to existing plants. Sewer network work has been completed in 114 unauthorised colonies at a cost of ₹2,012 crore, providing household connections to 1,28,633 homes. Work is currently underway in 276 more colonies, with connections planned for over 5.44 lakh households across 647 unauthorised colonies.

The Chief Minister said water treatment plants of 50

cial said. Sampling for H1N1 has also increased, with nasal swabs being collected from suspected patients and sent to laboratories for testing.

The Government said Delhi is implementing the health advisory issued by the Centre, which has been communicated to hospitals and concerned departments for compliance and coordinated action.

"There is no need for panic. Our health system is fully prepared and we are continuously monitoring the situation. At the same time, we cannot be complacent. Our priority is early detection, timely treatment, effective prevention and keeping the people of Delhi informed and protected," Singh said.

fully inspected due to safety and water-flow conditions, detailed investigation has been recommended. Repair measures include debris and silt removal, restoration of damaged protective concrete and additional scour protection wherever required.

The minister said the flywalk ramp steelwork has also emerged as a priority area, with severe corrosion, rust scaling, coating failure and corrosion at joints, splices and fastenings. Detailed assessment and rehabilitation of affected steelwork will be undertaken.

The inspection has further recommended corrective measures for steel deck corrosion, pylon coating deterioration, stay-cable anchorage protection, wax leakage, expansion-joint cleaning, drainage maintenance and deficiencies in certain penum-bearing components.

The elevated bridge opened for public use in 1918 and is Delhi's first asymmetrical cable-stayed bridge. It connects Hazirabad to Karawal Nagar and Bhajanpura in east Delhi and provides strategic connectivity to the Outer Ring Road, Loni in Hazirabad, Rajinder Nagar, and northeast and central parts of the national capital.

The structure was constructed at an estimated cost of about ₹1,518.37 crore by the DTDC and PWD took over the maintenance responsibilities last year.

Around 4,000 women will receive sanction letters under the Delhi Government's Lakshmi Yojana at an event at Talkatora Stadium on Wednesday, with the monthly financial assistance under the scheme set to be credited to beneficiaries from September 1, officials said.

The Chief Minister's Office said on X that the scheme will be formally launched on August 26, with eligible women receiving their sanction letters. According to the CMO, 9.13 lakh beneficiaries have registered on the portal, of whom 6.52 lakh have submitted completed applications. The Lakshmi Yojana was one of the main poll promise of the BJP government of 2025 Delhi election.

From September 1, ₹2,500 will be transferred every month directly into the bank accounts of eligible beneficiaries. The Government had also finalised the manner in which the assistance can be disbursed. Beneficiaries can choose to receive ₹1,000 through a central bank digital currency and invest ₹1,500 in a fixed or recurring deposit, or put the entire ₹2,500 into the deposit.

The applicants will also get an opportunity to correct or complete missing information. A correction facility will soon be made available on the Delhi Lakshmi Yojana portal, according to the CMO.

The scheme provides monthly assistance to eligible women aged between 21 and 60 years. Women from households with more than three children and those with annual household electricity consumption exceeding 2,400 units are among those excluded. The Government launched the application portal for the scheme on August 1.

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IN FOCUS



Mahouts stand near decorated elephants amid the Shivelì procession as part of the Onam celebrations, at Thrikkakkara Temple in Kochi, Tuesday

PTI

Maharashtra law puts religious freedom under fresh scrutiny

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Mumbai

With the anti-conversion law coming into force in Maharashtra, churches across the Mumbai Metropolitan Region (MMR) have begun asking worshippers to fill a self-declaration form, specifying that they are attending prayers of their own will and not under pressure.

These filled declaration forms, taken for “self-safety”, will be kept in the church offices to be shown to government or police authorities, if asked, pastor Sam Mathai from Vasai in neighbouring Palghar district told PTI on Tuesday.

The collection of forms from worshippers has been underway for the past two to three months, he said.

Mathai claimed that in the last six months, there have been 11 attacks on churches in the MMR area, especially Vasai-Virar, Palghar, Nalasopara and Bhayander, the satellite towns adjoining Mumbai.

“Right-wing groups enter churches without intimation and beat up people. It was then that pastors and community leaders came together to find a solution. We



Mount Mary Church in Bandra, Mumbai. Representative image

WIKIMEDIA COMMONS

don't force anyone to come and pray. The Indian Constitution allows everyone to pray of their own will,” he stated.

There are over 4,000 churches in MMR. Some churches are taking forms from worshippers who are not born Christians, and some are asking even the regular worshippers to fill the forms, Mathai informed.

Maharashtra's anti-conversion law, the Maharashtra Freedom of Religion Act, 2026, has come into force following Presidential assent

and its official gazette notification on July 30. It paves the way for action against religious conversions carried out through coercion, fraud, inducement or marriage.

Under the new law, a person intending to embrace another faith must inform the district magistrate at least 60 days in advance. The law provides for punishment of seven years in jail for violations of procedures.

Pastor Devdan Tribhuvan from Bhandup in Mumbai said churches have the database of regular worshippers.

“We are peaceful people and never retaliate. We have decided to get a self-declaration from those who come to the church that they are coming to pray at the church,” he said.

Worshippers who come every Sunday for the prayers are worried. In the last two years, there have been attacks on churches by people who forcibly disrupt prayers to inquire about the proceedings, alleged Tribhuvan, who is the president of the Christian Development Association.

Delhi Government bets on AI-ready data



PIONEER PHOTO

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi government has signed a MoU with EKStep Foundation, to make its administrative data AI-ready for improved governance and service delivery.

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Tuesday chaired a workshop of Delhi government officers, saying data systems must be interconnected to ensure that benefits of AI reach the ordinary people.

The initiative will make Delhi government data more organised, reliable and ready for use, according to a Delhi CMO statement.

The workshop attended by Delhi government secretaries, heads of departments and senior officials, focused on using data more effective-

ly to strengthen evidence-based decision-making, enable the government to provide services proactively based on people's needs, and improve public services.

Chief Minister Gupta said the benefits of AI should reach those who need them the most. “Data is the fuel for AI, and it is essential to make data useful for empowering citizens,” she said.

EKStep Foundation will work as a knowledge partner to the Delhi government and share its open frameworks and expertise under the MoU signed with Planning department.

Under the agreement, the two sides will work together to make government data ready for AI use and develop various use cases aimed at improving citizen services with the help of AI.

Road accident uncovers gold smuggling ring in UP

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ New Delhi/Lucknow

Central security agencies and the Customs Department have widened their investigation into a gold smuggling network after seizing 10.35 kg of gold bars worth about ₹16 crore on the Agra-Lucknow Expressway in Kannauj on Saturday. The investigation connects the operation to the Indo-Nepal border area of Thuthibari in Maharaajanj district. This has led to joint raids by Customs, Sashastra Seema Bal (SSB), and local police, focusing on car driver Sandeep Jaiswal and cloth merchant Riyaz.

A routine car accident helped investigators discover a cross-border network. They believe this group is part of a larger operation moving gold from Nepal into Indian markets through Uttar Pradesh.

The incident late night near the Talgram police station area. A police team was returning from Kanwar Yatra duty in a Tata Sumo when a speeding Maruti Brezza crashed into their vehicle. The impact pushed the police car onto the central divider, but all five officers were safe. The people in the Brezza



Recovered gold

PIONEER PHOTO

appeared nervous and tried to escape, but their car broke down.

When police searched the car, they found a black bag containing ten gold bars. An authorised State Bank of India evaluator confirmed the bars were 24-carat pure gold, weighing between 10.026 kg and 10.35 kg, and valued at ₹15.39 crore to ₹16 crore. The men could not show any bills, licences, or ownership documents.

The two men were identified as Sandeep Jaiswal, aged 28, from Thuthibari in Maharaajanj, and Saroj Pant, 33, from Hungi village in Nepal's Palpa district. After initial questioning at Talgram police station, both men and the gold were handed over to Customs and taken to Lucknow for

further questioning. GST officials at the scene quickly suspected an international smuggling racket because a Nepali national was involved and the amount of gold was large.

During questioning, Jaiswal and Pant gave important details. Jaiswal said that cloth merchant Riyaz, who owns Riyaz Vastralaya in Thuthibari and lives on the Bypass, told him to go to Gorakhpur. There, Pant handed him the bag with the gold bars.

Their job was to deliver the gold to an unknown person in Delhi's Daryaganj market, using only a vehicle number and a code word. They also admitted to moving three gold bars from Nepal to Delhi three days earlier. Customs found that

the same Brezza had entered Nepal through the Maheshpur border on the morning of 21 August with a short-term pass and returned that evening, staying longer than allowed.

The investigation then focused on the border area. Teams comprising Customs officers from Nautanwa, Thuthibari, and Nichlaur, along with SSB personnel and local police, conducted intensive raids throughout Thuthibari. Jaiswal's home was searched for documents, mobile phones, and financial records. At the same time, Riyaz's house and cloth shop were raided, but he was not there.

Sources say the accused admitted to being involved in several earlier shipments, possibly moving gold worth large sums over the past three months. Authorities are now checking border records and financial transactions to confirm these claims.

The case has also become political. Samajwadi Party chief Akhilesh Yadav claimed that 26 gold bars were found, but the police showed only 10 kg. Kannauj police and senior officials denied his claim, calling it baseless and politically motivated.

GOLCHA TO HEAD DELHI HOME GUARDS

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Senior IPS officer Satish Golcha, who served as Delhi Police commissioner until last month, will take over as Director General of Home Guards, Delhi, from October 1, according to an order issued by the Delhi government on Tuesday.



Senior IPS officer Satish Golcha

PIONEER PHOTO

Golcha, a 1992-batch AGMUT cadre IPS officer, has been transferred and posted as Officer on Special Duty (OSD) in the Directorate of Home Guards until the superannuation of incumbent DG Virender Singh, a 1991-batch IPS officer, on September 30.

No new H1N1 strain in India, ICMR chief urges calm

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The current surge in H1N1 infections in India is part of the seasonal influenza pattern and no new strain has been identified, ICMR Director General Dr Rajiv Bahl said, urging people not to panic as most cases are mild and self-limiting.

Addressing the media, Dr Bahl said the current influenza situation is being continuously monitored.

“The influenza viruses currently circulating in the country are consistent with the seasonal pattern observed in recent years. The ongoing genomic and epidemiological surveillance through the network of 73 DHR-ICMR Virus Research and Diagnostic Laboratories (VRDLs) has provided important reassurance,” he said.

The circulating Influenza A (H1N1) viruses have been identified as A/Missouri/11/2025 (H1N1) pdm09-like viruses.

Hemagglutinin (HA) gene analysis places the isolates in clade 6B.1A.5a2a; subclade D.3.1.1. The Indian Council of Medical Research (ICMR)



ICMR DG Dr Rajiv Bahl

ICMR.GOV.IN

director general (DG) informed that this lineage has been in continuous circulation in India since 2025. The genetic changes observed are consistent with the normal antigenic drift seen in seasonal influenza viruses.

Such minor genetic changes occur routinely as influenza viruses circulate and, by themselves, do not indicate the emergence of a new or dangerous strain, he said.

Dr Bahl emphasised that the present observations, therefore, do not indicate the emergence of a new influenza threat and are consistent with the expected behaviour of seasonal

influenza viruses.

Seasonal influenza, including Influenza A (H1N1), is predominantly a mild and self-limiting respiratory illness in otherwise healthy individuals. Common symptoms include fever, cough, sore throat, headache, body ache, fatigue and weakness.

In most people, symptoms improve with supportive care and adequate rest and hydration, the ICMR DG said. The presence of H1N1 does not, by itself, mean that a person will develop severe disease or require hospitalisation, he added.

Dr Bahl said there is no urgent need to take the vaccine against Flu. He added that individuals above 65 and immunocompromised may discuss the vaccine with their doctors but right now there is no need for everyone to take it. He informed that it is only a recommendation from the WHO and it is not even in the National Immunisation Programme.

He said that while seasonal influenza is generally mild, certain individuals have a higher risk of developing complications.

Doval, Wang reopen border talks

The mechanism, created in 2003, covers the 3,488-km India-China frontier and has become a key channel for managing tensions and maintaining high-level communication between Beijing and New Delhi.

Ahead of his meeting with Wang, Doval met Chinese Vice President Han Zheng after arriving in Beijing on Monday. Discussions focused on maintaining peace and stability along the border and expanding cooperation in economic, political and multilateral areas.

Han urged both countries to approach their relationship with a long-term strategic outlook. He called for greater mutual trust, stronger cooperation and closer coordination in multilateral forums, while stressing the need to manage differences carefully.

The engagement follows a period of severe strain in ties triggered by the 2020 Galwan Valley clash and the ensuing military confrontation in eastern Ladakh. Although subsequent diplomatic and military-level engagements have helped reduce tensions, the broader boundary dispute remains unresolved.

The Special Representatives mechanism has not produced a final settlement of the border question, but officials on both sides continue to regard it as an important avenue for addressing disputes and preventing disagreements from escalating.

China said the latest round would involve detailed discussions not only on the boundary issue but also on bilateral, regional and international matters. Beijing has described the Special Representatives dialogue as the principal channel for negotiations on the boundary question.

The previous round, held in August 2025, resulted in what China described as candid exchanges and several areas of common understanding. The latest meeting is expected to build on those understandings, with both sides seeking to preserve peace and tranquillity along the frontier.

The talks are being closely watched in the context of Xi's expected India visit. A meeting between Xi and Modi on the sidelines of the BRICS summit could provide an opportunity for the two leaders to discuss the next phase of India-China engagement.

Modi and Xi last met in August 2025 during the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation summit in Tianjin. Since then, both countries have continued efforts to stabilise ties while keeping the boundary issue and other strategic differences under discussion.

For New Delhi, the immediate priority remains maintaining peace along the frontier while seeking progress on unresolved issues. For Beijing, the emphasis has been on restoring strategic trust and expanding cooperation without allowing outstanding disputes to derail the wider relationship.

Against this backdrop, the Doval-Wang dialogue could serve as an important indicator of whether the recent efforts to stabilise India-China ties can translate into sustained diplomatic progress.

Bihar students clash with police over BPSC exam

The protesters were joined by a number of activists associated with organisations like SFI and DYFI, in a procession that began at the historic Gandhi Maidan, which has witnessed many upheavals in the near and recent past.

Tight security arrangements were in place along the nearly 5 km stretch from Gandhi Maidan to the CM's residence, and police used water cannons at JP Golambar, the starting point of the procession, only to behold the protesters break into a “rain dance”, in a stark reminder of the scenes witnessed last month when a ‘Raj Bhavan march’ was staged last month in support of the ‘Gen Z protests’ held at Jantar Mantar in Delhi.

“We repeatedly urged the crowd to maintain peace. We told them that we will help them send a delegation to authorities concerned to register their demands. Water cannons were used when

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the situation became tense,” Patna Senior Superintendent of Police Kartikeya Sharma said.

The protesters broke past the barricades to reach Dak Bungalow crossing, the city's busiest thoroughfare that leads to the Patna Junction as well as vital installations like Patna High Court and the Income Tax Office.

Several protesters were detained and taken away to various locations by the police, though the number of such persons and other details were not known. Many of the protesters were also heard venting spleen against a remark by BPSC examination controller Rakesh Kumar Singh on Monday when he had allegedly belittled the agitators, who had been staging a *dharna* at Gardani Bagh for several weeks, by using the Hindi proverb *Hathi chale bazaar, kutta bhunke hazaar* (The elephant walks through the market while a thousand dogs bark.).

The protesters said the BPSC must not only address their grievances with regard to the examination system but also act against the foul-mouthed examination controller, “who had likened them to barking dogs”.

Singh's remarks had drawn sharp criticism from Opposition leaders like RJD working president Tejashwi Yadav and the examination controller issued a video statement voicing regret and asserting, “I just used a proverb. It was not my intention to offend anybody.”

DGCA mulls year-round drug tests for pilots

At present, regulations require random psychoactive substance tests to be conducted on 10% of pilots and air traffic controllers, among other aviation personnel, each year. The ministry is now examining whether testing should instead cover all commercial pilots through random checks conducted at different times during the year.

“There are multiple ways of approaching this dope test,” Naidu said while speaking to

reporters on the sidelines of an event in New Delhi. He added that the DGCA was seeking the views of stakeholders before deciding on any changes to the current system.

The issue has gained renewed attention following an incident involving an Air India flight operating from Phuket to Delhi. The captain of the flight subsequently tested positive for marijuana after the aircraft experienced a sudden loss of altitude during its journey.

India has more than 12,000 pilots working across commercial airlines, making the scope and frequency of any expanded testing programme a significant consideration for the aviation sector.

The Federation of Indian Pilots (FIP) had earlier called for tighter testing measures. On August 18, the pilots' body asked the DGCA to consider oral-fluid testing as an additional screening method alongside the existing urine-based procedure. It also recommended raising the proportion of randomly tested pilots and other personnel from 10% to 25%.

Air India and Air India Express have separately introduced mandatory psychoactive substance testing for all their pilots following the Phuket-Delhi incident.

The Aircraft Accident Investigation Bureau (AAIB) is investigating the August 4 incident in accordance with Annex 13 of the International Civil Aviation Organization (ICAO), which sets out international standards and procedures for aircraft accident and incident investigations.

The flight, AI2379, was operated by an Airbus A320 registered as VT-EXO. During the cruise phase, the aircraft suddenly lost around 300 feet of altitude before stabilising. It later landed safely in Delhi.

The DGCA's stakeholder consultations are expected to help determine whether India's existing testing requirements should be expanded and whether a more comprehensive, year-round random testing system should be introduced for commercial pilots.

Shah's security push for 2047

Shah pointed to the overnight ban and dismantling of the Popular Front of India (PFI) as an example of coordination between the Union Government and the States and urged the use of the 'PRAHAR' framework in daily operations to eliminate terrorism and break up terrorist networks.

The home minister also spoke about the *Control Vision Document 2026-2029* to protect the younger generation, focusing on the three D's — Detect, Disrupt, and Destroy — to achieve a drug-free India. “It is only India that can carry out the most effective struggle against narcotics, and this struggle will be carried out jointly by the Government of India and by each department of each State Government and will therefore be won,” Shah said.

He highlighted new technology, saying that an integrated database combining CCTNS, ICJS, NatGrid, and NAFIS is now in place. He encouraged young officers to use data integration, analysis, and artificial intelligence to gather useful intelligence and prevent future issues. The Multi-Agency Centre (MAC) has also been upgraded to deliver better results.

Between 2019 and 2026, about 274 fugitives were brought back from abroad. Shah stressed that all states should ensure that remaining fugitives overseas are brought to justice in accordance with their countries' security interests, and that security policy must address global instability, energy and resource shortages, supply chain disruptions, rising radicalisation, and cyber misinformation.

He summed up by saying, “We must identify the challenges at an early stage and eliminate them before they turn into major problems. By establishing such an ecosystem, we will be able to create an India that is secure, free from infiltrators, and free from narcotics.”



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26 अगस्त, 2026



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States Focus



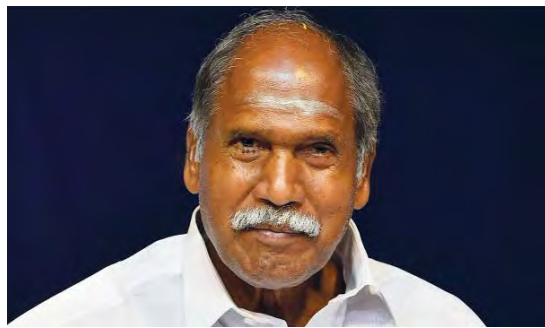
MURMU GREETES CITIZENS ON EVE OF ONAM, PROPHET'S BIRTHDAY

President Droupadi Murmu on Tuesday greeted citizens on the eve of the harvest festival Onam and Eid-e-Milad-un-Nabi, the birthday of Prophet Muhammad.

In a message, she said Onam is an occasion to express gratitude to nature on the arrival of the new harvest.

"Onam celebrates our rich culture and spirit of brotherhood. It promotes unity in diversity. Boat races, folk dances, music and sports are important traditions associated with this festival. They showcase the culture and values of Kerala," President Murmu said.

The president prayed that this auspicious festival brings happiness, peace, good health and prosperity to all, and inspires the citizens to contribute to the nation's progress, according to a statement issued by her office. (PTI)



GOVT TAKING STEPS TO ENSURE WATER SUPPLY: PUDUCHERRY CM

Chief Minister N Rangasamy told the Assembly on Tuesday that the Government had taken steps to ensure adequate and potable drinking water across the union territory.

Intervening in the debate on the motion of thanks to the Lieutenant Governor's address, Rangasamy said the administration had initiated measures, particularly in urban areas, to ensure a regular supply of drinking water amid complaints from some areas about brackish water.

Rangasamy said the Government had proposed a seawater desalination project and was considering drilling deep borewells, up to 1,700 feet, in rural areas such as Pandasozhanallur and Sivanthagam. (PTI)

Worker killed, two injured as flyover portion collapses in J&K

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Jammu

A construction worker engaged by a private engineering company on the Delhi-Amritsar-Katra Expressway was killed, and two others sustained injuries on Tuesday when an under-construction portion of an elevated flyover collapsed near Jakh in the Vijaypur area of Samba district and the Sidhra area of Nagrota in Jammu.

The deceased worker has been identified as 26-year-old Gotam Sahu. He hailed from the Samastipur district of Bihar. He was crushed to death in the course of a segment launching near Jakh. His dead body was retrieved from the accident site after a gap of two long hours. Angry workers staged



a protest demanding adequate compensation for the next of kin of the deceased worker.

According to coworkers, Gotam Sahu is survived by his wife and three minor kids, including two daughters and one son. Another labourer suffered head injuries and was evacuated to nearby AIIMS, Vijaypur hospital, the officials said. In

Winning elections just start of next battle: Lal Singh

ABHINAV KUMAR JHA
■ New Delhi

In the corridors of the Bharatiya Janata Party, winning an election has never been the finish line. It is, as the party's newly appointed national vice president Lal Singh Arya describes it, merely the starting gun for the next one.

Days after being elevated from national president of the party's Scheduled Caste Morcha to one of 13 national vice presidents under BJP chief Nitin Nabin, Arya used his first detailed interview since the promotion to lay out a philosophy that has powered his party's rise across the country: govern as if the next election has already begun. "For us, an election is never a one-time event," Arya said. "The day we win, we go back into campaign mode. We serve people honestly, we deliver development, and we keep winning

their trust. That is the method. That is the mantra we all follow."

It is a claim that, coming from a lesser leader, might sound like routine political posturing. But Arya backed it with numbers that are difficult to dismiss. The BJP today leads NDA Governments in 22 states, he pointed out, and is on course for an unprecedented third consecutive term at the Centre, a feat only a handful of parties in India's democratic history have managed.

"This did not happen by chance," Arya said. "A party whose roots run deep, that has struggled, built its own traditions, and won the hearts of ordinary people over decades, does not treat elections as occasional battles. It treats every day as preparation."

He went further, suggesting the BJP's ambitions are not limited to States it already governs. In states where the



party is yet to form a Government, he said, a shift is quietly underway. People, he claimed, are increasingly convinced that only the BJP can deliver the development their States need, and it is only a matter of time before that sentiment translates into votes.

Asked how the party decides who gets what responsibility, an especially pointed question given his

own journey from a caste-specific organisational post to a mainstream leadership role, Arya offered a glimpse into how the BJP's internal machinery works. He described it as a system of quiet observation, where the party watches how a worker performs before deciding where to place him next. "The party decides, I execute," he said. "It is like choosing the right soldier for the right

post, someone who can actually deliver on what is expected of him."

The conversation then turned to an unlikely chapter in Arya's own political career, one that still draws curious smiles from journalists and colleagues alike. Long before he became a national vice president, Arya served as India's first-ever Happiness Minister, heading a newly created department in the Madhya Pradesh Government under then chief minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan.

It was, by his own admission, a portfolio that invited plenty of scepticism when it was announced. "People used to ask me, quite openly, what does a Happiness Ministry even do," Arya recalled, with what appeared to be a mix of amusement and pride. "Even people close to me weren't sure if it was a serious department or just an unusual title someone had dreamed up."

He credited Chouhan with the original vision behind the idea, describing it as an experiment in governance that looked beyond roads and infrastructure to something harder to measure, public wellbeing itself. Despite the early mockery, Arya insisted the department carried out real initiatives during his tenure, and predicted that India would slowly come to appreciate the value of Governments thinking about happiness as seriously as they think about growth.

For a leader who has spent decades in the trenches of Madhya Pradesh politics and five years building the BJP's Dalit outreach machinery nationally, the message in this interview was unmistakable.

In Arya's BJP, there is no such thing as a party at rest, only a party perpetually campaigning for the next mandate.

Mamata accuses Suvendu of threatening her with house arrest

SAUGAR SENGUPTA ■ Kolkata

War of words ensued between Suvendu Adhikari and Mamata Banerjee, with the latter wondering whether she had been kept under house arrest after the Bengal Chief Minister asked her to remain indoors instead of creating a nuisance for his Government.

In what the Trinamool Congress chief described as a "new low" in Indian politics, Banerjee alleged that Adhikari was "threatening me with house arrest," after the Chief Minister asked her to remain indoors.

Suvendu Adhikari "while seated in a Government office, has brazenly threatened me, publicly declaring that he will ensure I cannot even leave my home," Banerjee alleged, saying she would like to call upon the President of India and the people of the country to see things for themselves.

Apparently targeting the Chief Minister, she said, "political power can scare you for some time", but it was the people who give the final reply against "arrogance."



The dispute comes amid rising embers over the alleged "selective" and "delayed" disbursement of monthly financial assistance of ₹3,000 for eligible women in Bengal under the Annapurna Bhandar scheme.

The war of words also ensued in the wake of Banerjee saying that she would not retire from politics and that she would live till she saw the end of the BJP from the country.

Reacting to the allegations levelled by the TMC chairperson regarding "mismanagement" of the Annapurna Bhandar scheme and resultant protests,

Adhikari had allegedly said that there were lots of false charges being levelled by his predecessor, asking her to refrain from sullyng the State politics and remain indoors instead. He would ensure that Banerjee remained indoors, the TMC chief alleged.

Adhikari had said, "Let her stay on Facebook in the afternoon; she doesn't need to come out on the streets. I will make arrangements to ensure that she cannot come out on the streets."

Referring to the delayed implementation of the Annapurna scheme, Adhikari said that everyone save the ineligible candidates would get the benefits of the scheme. "There is no point pressurising me because this scheme would apply to only those people who are eligible," Adhikari said.

Incidentally a number of TMC leaders including former Ministers who have been taken into custody by the police on various charges of corruption, violence etc after the fall of the Trinamool Government early this year there have been several incidents of egg attacks on them from the public.

High Court restrains police from arresting Abhishek Banerjee

SAUGAR SENGUPTA
■ Kolkata

In a big relief for Trinamool Congress general secretary Abhishek Banerjee, the Calcutta High Court on Tuesday restrained the police from taking coercive measures against him in three criminal cases till November 30.

After hearing both sides, the Bench of Justice Saugata Bhattacharya directed Banerjee to cooperate with the police, holding, however, that interrogation was presently not necessary. The Court also directed the police to serve a notice to the TMC MP from Diamond Harbour at least 48 hours before the hearing and submit a report before it regarding the progress of the investigation process. Tuesday's order



would not have any bearing on a previous Supreme Court order allowing Banerjee to travel out of India for treatment. Banerjee is also the nephew of former Bengal Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee.

"The order passed today shall not in any way curtail the right of the petitioner to go abroad for treatment in

terms of the order passed by the Hon'ble Supreme Court on August 10, 2026, for treatment, subject to compliance of conditions mentioned in the said order," the Tuesday order read.

Banerjee has been facing several cases, including those of corruption and publicly threatening the Opposition leaders.

IIT-Delhi sets up inquiry committee to probe MSc student's death

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Indian Institute of Technology (IIT) Delhi has constituted a five-member External Inquiry Committee to investigate the circumstances leading to the death of MSc Physics student Rishikesh Kumar, two days after nearly 300 students protested on campus demanding an independent inquiry into his death. The institute has asked the committee to submit its report within two weeks. The development comes after outraged students staged protests on campus, prompting the administration to order suspension of classes on Monday.

The committee comprises former Uttarakhand Director General of Police Ashok Kumar, who is also an IIT Delhi alumnus and currently Vice Chancellor of Sports University Haryana; Professor Pratap Sharma, Head of the Department of Psychiatry at AIIMS New Delhi; two student representatives; and the IIT Delhi Registrar, who will serve as the secretary and



convenor. The panel will interact with relevant students, faculty members, and administrative offices, review existing protocols and processes, and make recommendations based on its findings.

"The institute will ensure that the committee is given the necessary mandate to examine the matter comprehensively and to identify any further measures that may be required to strengthen student support systems. "In addition, an external ombudsperson is proposed to be appointed to address

student grievances that remain unresolved through the existing internal mechanisms," the official added. The institute has further invited students to come forward with their suggestions and concerns so that it can continuously improve its systems and create a safer, more responsive and supportive campus environment.

The 31-year-old MSc Physics student died on Saturday after allegedly jumping from the sixth floor of a campus building. Police said there was no suicide note, but a mobile phone found in the

deceased's pocket would be examined. Prima facie, no injury marks other than those attributable to the fall were found on his body, they added. As part of the investigation, the student's counselling records and other relevant information are being obtained from the institute, the police said, adding that they are looking into the circumstances leading to his death and verifying all available information.

According to an email sent by IIT Delhi Director Rangan Banerjee to students early Tuesday morning, the committee will speak to relevant students and faculty members, examine the functioning of concerned administrative offices, review existing protocols and processes, and make recommendations. "We are deeply saddened by the untimely loss of Rishikesh Kumar, our MSc Physics student," Banerjee said in the email.

"The student joined IIT-Delhi in July 2025 and was residing in a hostel on campus. He was an academically bright student. Following concerns raised

by fellow students a few days after the Holi festivities earlier this year, he was immediately referred to the IIT-Delhi Hospital through the institute ambulance. He was assessed and supported by the institute psychiatrist, following which his family said that they want to take him to a specialised hospital," an IIT-Delhi statement said.

"Thereafter, he underwent approximately one month of inpatient treatment at the specialised hospital before being discharged. The student subsequently requested withdrawal from the second semester (Jan-May 2026), which was approved by the institute. In July, his health records were reviewed, and medical advice was again given that he should continue to remain under parental supervision.

"He was provided counselling and treatment support by the institute counsellor/doctor in both July and August 2026. His request for withdrawal from the third semester (July-Nov 2026) was also approved by the institute," the statement added.

Betrayal of people: Congress slams Govt's caste census format

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Congress on Tuesday alleged that the way the caste census was being conducted in the country was a "betrayal of the people", "self-sabotage" and a "whitewash" by the Government, as it asserted that the caste count in its present form was unacceptable.

Congress general secretary Jairam Ramesh made the assertion at a press conference after releasing to the media the latest letter by Leaders of the Opposition Mallikarjun Kharge and Rahul Gandhi to Prime Minister Narendra Modi over the caste census issue.

"The Congress party believes that the way the caste census is being conducted in the country is a betrayal of the people. Instead of deceiving the public, the Modi Government should conduct the caste census in the country in the right and honest manner," Ramesh said.



Congress general secretary Jairam Ramesh

"The chief minister who got it done in Bihar is now with the NDA; they should get it done in the manner it was done in Bihar and Telangana," the Congress leader said in an apparent swipe at JD(U) chief Nitish Kumar. Initially, Modi did not want to conduct a caste census for many years, but since the announcement of the census, he has been continuously doing "U-turns", Ramesh alleged.

"We will not accept the way this census is being conducted, because it is just

a whitewash. Leaders of our party have written several letters, to which no response has come yet, but we will not let go of this issue.

"We hope that Prime Minister Modi will take our letters and their suggestions seriously," Ramesh said at the press conference along with Congress' OBC Department head Anil 'Jai Hind' Yadav.

Ramesh said the notification on caste census stated that 40 questions would be asked and the 10th question would be linked to caste.

30 students hospitalised, one dead in Maharashtra

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Palghar

A seven-year-old student of a residential school in Maharashtra's Palghar district has died after suffering from high fever and breathing difficulties, while 30 others have been hospitalised with cold, cough and fever symptoms, prompting the authorities to form an SIT to conduct a probe.

Following the death of the student, the superintendent of the school was suspended for "gross negligence" in the discharge of duties, officials said, adding that the Food and Drug Administration (FDA) inspected the school's kitchen and collected grocery items for laboratory analysis.

The incident comes after three tribal girls died from a venomous snakebite after sleeping on the floor of a residential school hostel in Gadchiroli district earlier this month. In the Palghar case, a Class 1 student at the ashram school in Maswan developed high fever on August 22 and was taken to



30 children with cold, cough and fever symptoms hospitalised in Palghar

the local Primary Health Centre (PHC) for treatment.

When his fever returned on on Monday, the PHC medical officer noted dropping oxygen levels and advised transferring him by ambulance to the Rural Hospital in Manor. After the child was taken to the hospital, medical officers conducted an ECG and declared him dead, an official said. The exact cause of death will be determined once the post-mortem report is received, he added.

Following the incident, senior health and adminis-

tration officials visited the school, which houses 395 resident students out of 449 total enrollees, and a medical team conducted a full health screening on the campus.

As a precautionary measure, 30 students showing mild symptoms of cold, cough or fever were placed under medical observation at the Maswan PHC, where their condition was reported to be stable, the official said.

The Integrated Tribal Development Project officer Vishal Khatri visited the school and the health centre

to meet the hospitalised students and their parents. "As per the advice of the district health officer, a fresh health check-up drive was conducted at the Maswan ashram school. Essential measures for campus sanitation and water purification are being carried out in the institution, and all necessary precautions will be taken to prevent the recurrence of such unfortunate incidents," Khatri said.

A Special Investigation Team (SIT) has been constituted to conduct a detailed inquiry into the tragic death of the student, fix responsibility and recommend preventive measures, officials said on Tuesday.

Appropriate administrative action will be taken against the persons concerned upon receipt of the committee's report," stated the official release by the district administration, Palghar, an official statement said.

The school superintendent was suspended with immediate effect for gross negligence in the discharge of duties during the visit of the Additional Commissioner

of Tribal Development, it said. Additionally, show-cause notices were issued to the President and Secretary of the Adivasi Seva Mandal, Mumbai, the organisation operating the aided school, the statement added.

"The immediate priority of the administration is to ensure children get healthy soon and no such incidence is repeated. With that view, health check-up camps are being proactively held across all schools of Palghar and students showing any symptoms like fever, cold, cough, etc are being kept under observation," it said.

"Thirty students are under observation at the Maswan PHC, comprising 14 boys and 11 girls. Four girls and one boy have been shifted to the Rural Hospital, Manor, District Palghar, for further treatment on the advice of a paediatric specialist. The students are out of danger and stable, and they are only being held under observation as a precautionary measure," it added.

FDA officials also inspected the school kitchen.

Cooking ingredients, including spices, turmeric, chilli powder, and oil containers, were collected and dispatched for laboratory testing, the statement said.

Officials also reviewed pest prevention protocols and water purification systems on-site as part of the ongoing investigation.

An average of nearly one student died every day in Maharashtra's ashram schools over the last two years, taking the total death toll to 584 across state-run and Government-aided residential facilities during the period, officials said earlier this month.

The causes of death ranged from snakebites and sickle cell disease to serious illnesses, accidents, and suicides, they said. Facing severe criticism over the recent deaths of three tribal girls due to snakebite in Gadchiroli, the Government has initiated corrective measures, including the cancellation of the residential school's licence and comprehensive safety audits of all such facilities across the State.

MP HC hears Indore water contamination death case



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Indore

The Madhya Pradesh High Court on Tuesday held an important hearing into the deaths linked to contaminated drinking water in Indore's Bhagirathpura area, where 36 people died between December 26, 2025 and February 25, 2026.

A more than 600-page report prepared by a one-member judicial inquiry commission has already been submitted to the High Court. The commission, headed by retired Justice Sushil Kumar Gupta, was constituted on January 27 to examine the causes of water contamination, the role of officials, relief measures and compensation for affected families.

During the hearing, counsel appearing for the victims sought a copy of the report for detailed study. The court, however, declined to allow its public circulation. The report has been placed with the Principal Registrar, and concerned lawyers have been permitted to inspect it there. The next hearing is scheduled for September 8.

The court also took note of complaints that contaminated water is still being supplied in several parts of Indore. It asked the Municipal Corporation what action had been taken and why clean drinking water was not reaching certain areas.

The civic body informed the court that it had conducted water testing and that the results were expected within 48 hours. The report is likely to be placed before the court on Monday.

The inquiry commission examined several possible causes behind the Bhagirathpura tragedy,

including sewage entering drinking water pipelines, technical faults or damage to pipelines and the possibility of industrial pollution.

It also examined medical records and other evidence to determine how many people fell ill due to contaminated water and how many of the 36 deaths could be directly linked to it. The commission collected records from the Indore Municipal Corporation, Indore Development Authority, district administration and health department. Statements of affected residents were also recorded, while relief, treatment and public health arrangements during the incident were reviewed.

The role of several officials and employees also came under scrutiny during the inquiry. However, as the report remains sealed and has not been made public, no responsibility has yet been officially confirmed.

Senior counsel Ajay Bagadiya opposed distributing copies of the report to different parties, arguing that wider circulation could lead to selective interpretation and distract from the core issue of fixing accountability and preventing a repeat of such a tragedy. During the hearing, the quality of water supplied to Government hospitals was also raised. Bagadiya referred to random water samples reportedly collected from seven Government hospitals, of which five were said to have failed quality tests and showed the presence of E. coli and total coliform.

The court proceedings are now expected to focus on accountability, the findings of the judicial inquiry and measures required to ensure safe drinking water across Indore.

Gujarat hooch tragedy: 13 more arrested; 27 held so far



Gujarat Police officials conduct raid in Bhavnagar

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Bhavnagar

Gujarat Police have arrested 13 more persons in connection with the hooch tragedy in Bhavnagar, including a man from Madhya Pradesh who played a major role in the manufacture of the spurious liquor that claimed 13 lives, officials said on Tuesday.

With this, the total number of arrests in the tragedy that unfolded last week has risen to 27. Gujarat is a 'dry' State where the manufacture, sale and consumption of alcohol is banned.

Thirteen persons died after consuming spurious liquor packed in bottles with the label of a popular Indian-made foreign liquor (IMFL) brand. According to officials, 67 persons had consumed the liquor containing methanol, a highly toxic substance. "After thorough interrogation of the accused arrested earlier, the police's State Monitoring Cell (SMC) arrested 13 more accused on Sunday and remanded them in police custody till September 2," a police release said.

While a majority of those arrested are from Bhavnagar, one Anand Chhandi, a resident of Rajgarh district in MP, was brought to Bhavnagar from Ujjain to allegedly manufacture spurious liquor, and he has a "very big role" in the conspiracy. He also allegedly played a major role in the procurement of chemicals used in the manufacturing process, the police said.

As part of the investigation, the SMC seized bottles of liquor containing poisonous chemicals and earlier arrested 14 persons involved in the crime. As many as 16 teams of SMC, a special Gujarat police unit that tracks state-wide illicit liquor and gambling operations, spread out in Delhi, Madhya Pradesh, Rajasthan, Uttar Pradesh and Gujarat to gather evidence, the release said.

The police are investigating the source of methanol and other chemicals, the transporters involved, and all those linked to procuring and moving raw materials used in manufacturing spurious liquor.

The accused persons have been booked on several charges, including culpable homicide not amounting to murder, adulteration and poisoning, under the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita and Prohibition Act.

Bhojshala row: Hindu outfits call for Dhar bandh

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Dhar

Hindu organisations called for a half-day bandh in Madhya Pradesh's Dhar city on Tuesday, accusing the administration of not strictly enforcing the Supreme Court's order regarding the Bhojshala-Kamal Maula Complex dispute.

The administration stepped up security across the district following the bandh call.

The Supreme Court had directed the Muslim community to offer prayers at a designated site, survey number 596, but the administration is not complying, Bhoj Utsav Samiti President Suresh Jalodia claimed.

He said the district administration has selected another plot — survey number 612 — near the Bhojshala Complex, for prayers.

"This also blocks the road to the Bhojshala temple. In protest, the Sakal Hindu Samaj has called for a bandh till noon today in Dhar city," he said.

Members of Hindu outfits took out a motorcycle rally in the city, urging people to close their shops and businesses. At some locations, they were seen forcing people to close their shops. Heavy security was



deployed to maintain peace and law and order in Dhar, officials said.

The situation currently is completely peaceful and under control, City Superintendent of Police Shashank Singh Gurjar told PTI Videos. He said the administration was ensuring the bandh remains voluntary and that no business owner or person is pressured to close their establishment.

Dhar residents have been

appealed to ignore any misleading information or rumours, and to immediately inform the local police if they encounter any situation where they are forced to close their shops or are harassed, the official said.

Supporting the shutdown, Pradeep Rathore, a city hotelier, said they were protesting the administration's designated prayer site. "The prayer site should be 300

metres away (from Bhojshala)," he said. In May this year, the Madhya Pradesh High Court declared the Bhojshala-Kamal Maula complex a temple dedicated to Goddess Saraswati.

The matter subsequently reached the Supreme Court, which directed the state Government to allow the Muslim community to offer prayers at the Dargah complex adjacent to the disputed Bhojshala complex on Fridays between 1 pm and 3 pm.

Following the court's directive, the district administration made necessary arrangements for prayers at Survey number 612 site near the complex, and the Muslim community has been offering prayers there for the past few weeks.

The Muslim side had claimed the 11th-century monument to be the Kamal Maula Mosque, while the Hindu side claimed it was a temple built by King Bhoj of the Parmar dynasty, which was destroyed during the invasion by Alauddin Khilji. Following the court's decision, a large number of devotees come to worship at the monument every Tuesday, reciting Saraswati Vandana, Hanuman Chalisa, and performing havan (fire ritual).

Karnataka Governor suspends KPSC chairman

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Bengaluru

Karnataka Governor Thaawarchand Gehlot on Tuesday suspended the Karnataka Public Service Commission Chairman Shivashankarappa S Sahukar on the aid and advice of the state Cabinet on charges of corruption and large-scale irregularities.

This is the second time Shivashankarappa was suspended. The Governor had on July 13 suspended Sahukar, but the Karnataka High Court set aside the order on the grounds that the action lacked the 'aid and advice of the state cabinet'. On August 21, the state cabinet decided to recommend to the Governor to



Governor Thaawarchand Gehlot

suspend him. "As per the order of the Hon'ble High Court of Karnataka dated August 18, Hon'ble Governor of Karnataka, on the aid and advice of the State Cabinet on August 21 has suspend-

ed Shivashankarappa S Sahukar, Chairman, Karnataka Public Service Commission, under Article 317 (2) of the Constitution of India until further orders by the Hon'ble President of India," a statement issued by the Special Secretary to the Governor Prabhu Shankar.

Further, the next senior most member of the Karnataka Public Service Commission has been directed to act as the Chairman of the Commission until further Orders, the statement said. Sahukar was suspended by the Governor following allegations that he had facilitated the alleged illegal selection of his two daughters as Industrial Extension Officers.

Truck carrying pilgrims falls into gorge in HP

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Una/Shimla

At least 40 pilgrims from Haryana were injured after a truck they were travelling in fell into a gorge in Himachal Pradesh's Una district on Tuesday, officials said.

The devotees had come to pay obeisance at the Peer Nigah temple in the district. After offering prayers at the temple, they were on way to the Mata Naina Devi temple



Doctors and paramedical staff treating patients at Regional Hospital, Una

took place, they said.

Medical Superintendent of the Regional Hospital, Una, Dr Sanjay Mankotia

said, "More than 40 pilgrims injured in the Peer Nigah accident were brought to the Regional Hospital in Una

and are receiving treatment.

Three people, including a child whose condition was critical, have been referred to PGI Chandigarh after receiving initial treatment, he said.

Union Health Minister JP Nadda, Leader of Opposition and former chief minister Jai Ram Thakur, and BJP state chief Rajeev Bindal have expressed grief over the road accident and wished speedy recovery to the injured.



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Smearing your car with 3,400 lipstick kiss marks by your girlfriend can land the vehicle owner in trouble. He had to shell out a ₹5,500 challan, remove the marks and wash it to restore the exterior.

The incident in Gwalior came to light after a video went viral, raising curiosity. The police tracked down the car through its registration number and imposed the fine for violating traffic

rules under Motor Vehicles Act. The car, owned by Aditya Sikarwar, became the centre of attention after its entire exterior was covered with lipstick marks resembling kisses.

Photos of the vehicle quickly made their way across social media, prompting curiosity over the story behind its striking appearance. It was learnt, his girlfriend was inspired by a foreign social media trend and decided to recreate it on the car. The thousands of lip-

stick prints were made one by one and took around four hours to complete. The result was hard to miss. With kiss marks covering much of its exterior, the car stood out wherever it went, naturally drawing the attention of people on the road.

The car was driven around Gwalior's City Centre for two days before the video went viral. Traffic police traced the vehicle and imposed the fine on its owner under the Motor Vehicles Act, besides directing him to remove the

lipstick marks. Following the action, Aditya Sikarwar accepted his mistake. The lipstick marks were then removed from the car, with the vehicle being washed to restore its exterior.

The Gwalior man's unusual car makeover highlighted a lesser-known aspect of motor vehicle law -- vehicle owners cannot make modifications or alterations that violate prescribed rules.

The incident raises a relevant question for Delhi motorists: what modifica-

tions or practices can land a vehicle owner in trouble in the national capital?

A senior Delhi Traffic Police officer said a vehicle owner cannot freely alter a vehicle after purchasing it from a manufacturer.

"When someone buys a vehicle from a showroom, it complies with the prescribed traffic and motor vehicle guidelines. For any further changes, one has to take permission, which will be examined by the competent authority.

NC MP Ruhullah hints action after Farooq Abdullah's to quit call

MOHIT KANDHARI
■ Jammu

The simmering war of words within the Jammu and Kashmir National Conference erupted into a high-stakes public test on Tuesday, as Srinagar Lok Sabha MP Aga Syed Ruhullah Mehdi strongly hinted he would respond to party president Dr Farooq Abdullah's blunt demand that he resign and seek a fresh mandate from voters.

In an interview with a local news portal in Srinagar, National Conference President Dr Farooq Abdullah dared the Srinagar MP to resign from the Lok Sabha and seek a fresh mandate from the electorate. Speaking to reporters a day after Abdullah's challenge, Ruhullah reacted by saying, "It is not possible that Doctor Sahib asks me for something and I don't give it to him. It is not possible that I send him back empty-handed," he said. "He has asked for something at this age. I respect him. I don't want him to ask me for something, and I return it to



him empty-handed... I will answer in a few days."

Referring to his popularity, Dr Abdullah had also observed that if he (Aga Syed Ruhullah) believed his 2024 Lok Sabha victory stemmed primarily from personal support rather than the party's organisational strength, he should put it to the test: "If you think people voted for you, resign and go back to them. We will see how many votes you get."

Since last year, Ruhullah has repeatedly accused the party leadership of diluting its core promises, particularly restoration of Article 370, statehood and the constitu-

tional rights of Jammu and Kashmir.

Farooq Abdullah had said Ruhullah was free to raise the issue of Article 370 in Parliament, but questioned his approach to the matter.

"If he thinks Article 370 can be restored, he should take up the issue in Parliament," Abdullah said.

The NC president also defended the importance of party organisation and discipline, arguing that candidates contesting elections on the party ticket benefit from the support of the organisation and its workers. Ruhullah, however, has maintained that his political position reflects the mandate given to him by the people and has repeatedly argued that the fight for Jammu and Kashmir's constitutional rights remains unfinished.

In contrast, Dr Farooq Abdullah claimed Ruhullah was currently on the "wrong path." He invoked the sacrifices of generations of NC workers and advised Ruhullah to seek guidance from the 'Quran'.



Editor's
TAKE

The bitter truth: Sugar price go through the roof

An unprecedented jump in retail prices of sugar is a reminder of how Govt inaction can quickly turn a price rise of an essential kitchen item into a national concern

Sugar is not a luxury. It sweetens the morning chai at a highway dhaba and the payasam at a wedding feast alike. So when the price of this democratic commodity jumps nearly 40 per cent in a month – from ₹45-48 a kilogram in mid-July to ₹65 by late August, UP's ex-factory rate crossing a record ₹5,400 a quintal – it isn't a market footnote but a kitchen-table crisis.

The Centre ordered physical verification of stocks at every mill on July 24, completed it by August 14, then sat on the numbers as retail prices kept climbing. Only around August 22 – a month into the spike – did the Ministry of Consumer Affairs, Food and Public Distribution finally speak at length, its first instinct defensive: batting down the theory gaining ground on social media and in Parliament that ethanol blending was the culprit. That defensiveness is telling, because ethanol had become the easy villain. India hit its 20 per cent ethanol-blending target in petrol in 2025, five years ahead of the original 2030 deadline, so it is fair to ask whether diverting cane to fuel tanks has starved the sugar bowl. The government's own numbers say otherwise: sugar diverted to ethanol has actually fallen, from about 12 per cent in 2022-23 to roughly 9 per cent now, since nearly three-quarters of India's ethanol comes from grain, chiefly maize, not cane. Ethanol blending is a convenient scapegoat, not the real culprit.

The duller, more accurate story is disease and weather. Red rot and top borer infestation, worsened by waterlogging from excess rain, have pushed the outlook for the season starting in October down to roughly 30.6 million tonnes from an initial 34.3 million tonnes. Closing stock for the current season is projected at barely 3 to 3.5 million tonnes – among the thinnest cushions in decades – just as festival demand from Ganesh Chaturthi through Diwali peaks. Add a genuine global squeeze – international prices up 16 per cent in under two months on a projected 3.3-million-tonne world deficit – and old-fashioned hoarding by traders betting on further gains, and the price chart largely explains itself. None of this excuses the silence. A government holding mill-level stock data by mid-August owed the public that information before prices peaked, not a rebuttal of internet theories after the fact.

Transparency is itself a price-stabilisation tool; delay only feeds speculation and hoarding. The fixes on the table – duty-free imports of 10 lakh tonnes, stock limits on dealers till November, an earlier crushing start from October 15 – are sound but reactive.

The lasting answer lies upstream: faster disease-resistant cane varieties, production tracking that reflects ground reality rather than advance estimates revised down all season, a buffer stock insulated from the export-then-import flip-flops of recent years, and a Centre willing to publish bad news as promptly as it publishes denials.

Prices should cool once fresh cane reaches the crusher in October. Public trust, dented by a month of silence, will take longer to mend.

The new age of narrative warfare

What looks like an organic wave of outrage online may sometimes be carefully engineered. In this new age of psychological warfare, the most vulnerable society may not be the one with the weakest military, but the one that gradually loses the ability to distinguish truth from manipulation



ASHVATHAMA
N ALLIMUTHU

Wars once required weapons - armies crossing frontiers, nations measuring their safety in tanks and treaties, invasions you could see coming and fronts you could point to on a map. That world hasn't disappeared, but a second battlefield has opened quietly beside it — one fought not with bullets but with belief. A country can now be destabilised without a shot being fired: not through tanks at a border, but through engineered narratives, algorithm-driven opinion, and psychological conditioning at social-media scale. Call it what it actually is.

Not “online propaganda.” Not “digital activism.” This is cyber psychological warfare, and most of us are standing inside it without realising.

Consider what happens after any major Supreme Court observation. Within days, anonymous pages appear from nowhere, amassing followers and engagement that no ordinary account could earn organically in years of patient work.

Sudden, unexplained scale like that is rarely luck - more often, it's bot networks, coordinated engagement rings and paid amplification working in concert.

This deserves a name: Narrative Terrorism — a deliberate campaign to reshape what a population believes, fracture its unity, erode confidence in its institutions, and condition the young before they've learned to question anything. Conventional terrorism destroys buildings. Narrative terrorism destroys certainty. Its target isn't infrastructure. It's the mind.

What makes this form of warfare so effective is its invisibility. Nobody feels manipulated in the moment. Platforms are built to keep surfacing emotionally charged content, and repetition does the rest: exposure breeds familiarity, familiarity breeds acceptance, and acceptance eventually passes for truth. The economics reward this pattern: outrage travels faster than accuracy, anger out-competes nuance, division earns more attention than consensus.

India is unusually exposed here. As one of the world's youngest digital populations, its Gen Z consumes an extraordinary volume of content daily — reels, shorts, memes, influencer takes, anonymous opinion pages - often without the tools to separate verified reporting from propaganda, satire, paid promotion or ideological manipulation. That gap is exactly what outside actors, whether political, ideological, geopolitical or commercial, are built to exploit.



They don't need to attack India militarily. They only need to erode the trust binding citizens, institutions and communities together, because a divided society is a manipulable one.

This matches an old historical pattern: great civilisations are rarely toppled by armies at the gate. What actually finishes them off is what happens earlier — a citizenry too confused, too demoralised and too fractured to notice the gate was left open.

The contest has quietly relocated - from geography to psychology, from checkpoints to comment sections, from missiles to machine-learned feeds - and artificial intelligence raises the stakes further. AI systems learn from the information ecosystem around them, and an ecosystem already saturated with manipulated narratives and artificial amplification risks producing AI that echoes those same distortions back at a scale no single campaign could reach alone.

This isn't only India's problem; it's civilisational. As the world enters the AI era, India has a chance to lead not merely through technology, but by offering the deeper solution this moment actually demands: free thinking. A population capable of independent reasoning and genuine intellectual openness cannot be easily herded by algorithms or engineered narratives. India's most valuable export in the AI age may not be innovation at all, but the revival of a civilisation built to question.

That starts with how India educates its children. A society that only memorises isn't educated - it's just informed. Students need to be taught how algorithms work on emotion, how propaganda operates, how to verify a source, and how to tell information apart from conditioning. Machines can already retrieve facts instantly; the one human advantage still standing is judgement - the intellectual immunity to resist a narrative

even when it feels emotionally true.

India doesn't need to invent this capacity. It needs to remember it. The Upanishadic dialogues, Buddhist debate traditions and classical Tamil philosophy all treated inquiry as the essence of learning, not an interruption to it. The phrase “Neti, Neti” - not this, not this - was a civilisation practising the discipline of continuous doubt long before psychology gave manipulation a name.

So the response to narrative warfare cannot be purely technological. It has to be philosophical and educational too, aimed at producing citizens who verify before believing, question before reacting, understand how algorithms work on them, and value truth over virality.

None of this makes technology the villain. Fire can cook a meal or raze a city; the outcome depends on the hand holding it. AI, social media and algorithmic platforms can educate and unite just as easily as they can manipulate and divide - the responsibility sits with citizens, educators, technologists and policymakers alike.

India stands at a genuine crossroads: positioned, through its demographic weight and technological depth, to become the world's model for protecting intellectual independence, and to push for narrative manipulation to be treated as a serious matter of national security. Not every trend that goes viral is organic, not every influencer is independent, and not every movement is spontaneous. Borders once had to be crossed on foot; today they are crossed silently, through a screen. The strongest defence was never going to be firewalls or regulation alone - it is a citizenry that can still think for itself.

A people that think for themselves cannot be occupied from within. In the age of AI, that may be the fact on which democracy's survival ultimately rests.

The writer is State Secretary Tamil Nadu BJP; Founder, Project TamilAI & Science Saga - centre for free AI training for rural

Experience the love of God by taking his shelter



AJIT KUMAR
BISHNOI

2ND OPINION

I have sometimes wondered why a mother loves her baby so much and that too unconditionally. It is all one-sided! She looks after the baby the very best way possible in spite of her limitations, which all of us have. The baby wakes her in the middle of night. What does she do? Get upset? Far from it; she cleans him, as necessary, and feeds him. Have you seen a mother complain about the troubles her dear child gives her? Far from it; she even looks after the baby when she, herself, is not well.

Now the explanation for the above. Her child gives her, what is extremely precious to her. For the child,



his mother is everything; his loyalty is unflinching. My Lord, who loves me, gave me this insight, and, more importantly, one which follows. Because I have taken His shelter. My relationship with God is also one-sided. What can I give Him, who owns everything; doesn't He? Yes, my loyalty is all-important to God. This is what we all need to do, and our life will become sublime.

Just to give you an idea about what my Lord is doing for me, He has taken charge of me. Surely, my Lord must reform me in order that I become deserving of the highest reward of liberation in this life itself; no more of the painful cycle of birth and death for me. I am not ashamed to admit that I have plenty of lust, greed and hate.

There are big hindrances in my progress. They are all being got rid of systematically and very patiently.

My Lord even takes care that it is all done in a subtle way with my cooperation. They are not being delivered like hammer blows. My Lord has even made me His ‘nimitta’ (instrument) to carry out certain tasks, which give me a positive identity like I write spiritual articles under His guidance. I know in my heart that God does not need me; He has ‘ichcha shakti’ (divine will power). He can accomplish anything He chooses to do, but all the tasks my Lord has set for me are my necessities; I love them like looking after my family and the family business.

My Lord has mercifully provided all the resources I need to do my assigned duties. I have plenty of money, excellent help of all kinds, most importantly, sufficient energy at my age.

Believe me, I feel empowered to do what I must; it is a great feeling. All these are within my comfort zone suited to my unique nature. Even my deep desires are getting fulfilled, which, of course, are accordingly to ‘dharma’ (highest principles). Whatever bad my fate brings is taken care in a tolerable way. I am even able to not get spoiled by good things, which happen in my life. What more can I hope for or anyone can? I have never felt this good in my life. It is quite unbelievable; what I am experiencing.

The writer is a spiritual teacher and a columnist

CHENNAI NEEDS SUSTAINABLE AIRPORT EXPANSION, NOT FARMLAND LOSS

The decision to shelve the proposed Parandur airport project and protect farmland, water bodies and the livelihoods of local residents is a bold and welcome initiative. Development should not come at the cost of valuable agricultural resources, ecological balance and the well-being of affected communities.

Instead, the proposal to develop a new Terminal 5 in the north-western area of Chennai Airport, in collaboration with the Airports Authority of India (AAI), offers a practical and sustainable alternative. The project, along with an approach road and flyover, could make better use of existing airport infrastructure while providing greater convenience to passengers. AAI's technical expertise and cooperation could help the project progress efficiently and be completed

within a reasonable timeframe. Expanding Chennai Airport is increasingly important as passenger numbers and air traffic continue to grow. However, the government must avoid unnecessary delays in planning and execution. Any prolonged delay could place additional pressure on existing airport facilities and affect passenger convenience.

A clear timeline, effective coordination with AAI and timely construction are therefore essential. With careful planning, Terminal 5 could strengthen Chennai's aviation infrastructure while balancing development with environmental protection and the interests of local communities. This approach could become a model for responsible and sustainable urban development.

APTHIRUVADI, CHENNAI

Please send your letter to the info@dailypioneer.com. In not more than 250 words. We appreciate your feedback.

Concerns regarding the ownership and editorial independence of *The Pioneer*

I have been reading The Pioneer for many years. Recently, I saw a video in which Kalvakuntla Kavitha said that *The Pioneer* has been bought by BRS.

This has made me concerned about whether the newspaper is still independent and unbiased. I have been a regular reader for many years, so I would like to know whether these allegations are true.

If the newspaper is indeed under the control or influence of BRS, I would not feel comfortable continuing to read it. I sincerely hope that these allegations are not true and that *The Pioneer* continues to remain independent and impartial.

SUBODH | NEW DELHI

Sugar price rise needs government attention
The sharp rise in sugar prices, reaching ₹48 a kg and reportedly ₹55-63 in some markets, is a serious concern. With festivals approaching, higher sugar prices could increase sweet prices and strain household budgets. The government needs to maintain reasonable prices and protect consumers from further financial pressure. Such measures would provide much-needed relief to consumers.

KIRTI WADHAWAN | KANPUR

Bridging India-Russia's trade gap

The recent meeting between External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar and Russian President Vladimir Putin has once again highlighted the depth of India-Russia relations. While the two countries share strong strategic ties, the reported trade deficit of nearly \$50 billion points to an economic imbalance that requires urgent attention. India's imports from Russia have risen substantially, particularly due to increased energy purchases. However, Indian exports have failed to keep pace. A large and persistent trade gap could eventually limit the full potential of bilateral economic cooperation. India must therefore make greater efforts to expand its presence in the Russian market. There is significant potential for Indian pharmaceuticals, agricultural products, engineering goods, automobiles, textiles, electronics and consumer products. Simplifying payment mechanisms, improving transportation links and facilitating business-to-business cooperation could help Indian exporters overcome existing difficulties and increase sales in Russia.

The strong political relationship between the two countries should translate into a more balanced economic partnership. The Jaishankar-Putin engagement provides an opportunity to identify practical measures to narrow the trade deficit while opening new areas of cooperation.

RUKMA SHARMA | JALANDHAR

When merit takes a back seat

I refer to the article “Commercialisation Is Killing the Middle-Class Dreams” (Aug. 25). Both education and healthcare systems in our country have become extremely costly.

Middle-class and poor students can neither afford to pursue higher education nor dream of becoming doctors. Almost all private medical colleges are now owned and controlled by wealthy politicians who mint money by collecting donations for every admission. Merit has become a casualty in the bargain. NEET has come as a blessing in disguise for poor and middle-class students. Add to this the reservation system in vogue. The wards of IAS officers get preference in admission to prestigious institutions, while the son of a poor temple priest runs from pillar to post to secure admission to a prestigious institution.

I agree with the author that a nation that sells its classrooms to the highest bidder sells its own future. Why cannot the government provide innovative education and quality healthcare free of cost, since both consume people's lifelong savings? Nationalising both sectors could go a long way towards curbing this menace and easing people's agony.

N R RAMACHANDRAN | CHENNAI

Air turbulence more frequent and violent in warming planet

Turbulence avoidance is an important topic for research, and there are enough studies on North Atlantic and North Pacific routes. The relatively bump-free air experiences in future would need actionable forecasts using data on atmospheric information from many sources and artificial intelligence



While cruising through the clear sky, Air India flight AI2379 suddenly dropped 300 feet over the Indian airspace over the Bay of Bengal and Odisha on 4th August, and the turbulence injured 24 persons, including four crew members on board. Pilot in command (PIC) is found to have failed a dope test twice. Sources said that he consumed marijuana and, for 'high' behaviour on the flight, crew members have complained against him. The co-pilot steadied the aircraft and landed at the destination, Delhi. PIC has to face an enquiry under DGCA rules. The incident is alarming, and DGCA has made dope test rules more stringent for the safety of passengers in the air. The process of detecting consumption of psychoactive substances is difficult to find in breath analyser tests. Frequent random dope tests are the only answer. Marijuana's legal availability adds to the worries of airlines.

The aircraft is reported to have encountered air turbulence, leading to a few failures during the fall. The flight suffered triple hydraulic failure for a few seconds, which is rare. This system uses a fluid under pressure to drive machinery or move mechanical components to power critical elements like wheel brakes, nose wheel steering, landing gear retraction/extension, and flight control surfaces. Autopilot is also reported to have remained disengaged twice in that brief period.

The aircraft has also encountered negative G, for which pilots and crew could have been trained to handle, but not the passengers. DGCA's enquiry would reveal the extent to which the impact of the incident was avoidable, but let me examine in this piece how the warming planet would cause more serious bumps in air travel on some routes. There are two types of turbulence. One is convective turbulence, which is displayed by airborne weather radar, and the pilot has time to change the course, and the other is clear-air turbulence (CAT) generated by jet streams (narrow and fast-moving rivers of high-altitude winds) that are invisible to radar.

As the Indian sub-continent heats up from April till mid-June, moisture-laden air from the sea surface is moved up high in the atmosphere, forming cumulonimbus clouds stretching from a few thousand to 50,000 feet, influencing the movement of passenger jets. With the rise in temperature, more water evaporates from the sea surfaces, forming more intense clouds. Inside these clouds are lightning and hail, often forming a chain of cells, and pilots call the chain a squall line. The convective turbulence is thus captured by radar and visible on the cockpit screen. CAT, however, occurs above 15,000 feet due to sharp differences in the speed and direction of jet streams between adjacent layers, creating violent wind shear. Also, where fast and slow currents interact, eddies and whirlpools develop, and the aircraft encounters them in the sky. Scientific studies have found that climate change is increasing the temperature difference between tropical and polar air masses, causing the collision of the two at that altitude. It destabilises the jet stream, resulting in more turbulence. It is clear-air turbulence taking place without any cloud in the sky, and the pilots do not get any indication. The jet stream shear and the resulting turbulence do not show any sign on the cockpit screen, and can only be known from the bulletins issued by Significant Meteorological Information bulletins, which are issued to notify areas that are likely to be affected by jet stream turbulence.

The jet stream is a mid-latitude phenomenon and can impact the region in North India. It is a matter of enquiry whether the pilot missed the signal and failed to change the course. The turbulence recorded over the sea and in peninsular India is generally of the convective type. Sometimes even convective turbulence is not recorded on radar and gives no signal on the cockpit screen. It happens when fast-growing cells do not pick up enough moisture and fail to show on radar. This can happen during nights, especially when the aircraft flies in and out of the cloud.

How does climate change influence turbulence? First of all, it does not impact the atmosphere above all regions uniformly. It is because the jet stream shear has varying magnitude and direction across the regions. Across North Atlantic and North Pacific aviation routes, the wind shear



THERE ARE TWO TYPES OF TURBULENCE. ONE IS CONVECTIVE TURBULENCE, WHICH IS DISPLAYED BY AIRBORNE WEATHER RADAR, AND THE PILOT HAS TIME TO CHANGE THE COURSE, AND THE OTHER IS CLEAR-AIR TURBULENCE (CAT) GENERATED BY JET STREAMS (NARROW AND FAST-MOVING RIVERS OF HIGH-ALTITUDE WINDS) THAT ARE INVISIBLE TO RADAR

The writer is Retired Head of Forest Force, Karnataka, and teaches Economics at Karnataka Forest Academy

is substantial due to climate change, and the aircraft encounters relatively high turbulence. Also, the routes over the mountains such as the Alps, Rockies, Andes and Himalayas find strong winds forced over high terrain, making it more turbulent, and flights experience frequent and intense bumps.

The warming planet makes even convective turbulence more intense in tropical regions. Powerful thunderstorms may intensify due to high energy and more moisture pumped into the atmosphere from warmer sea surfaces. Though it can be visualised by the pilots in the cockpit and also confirmed on the screen and becomes unavoidable, the passengers have to face a bumpy flight, and the injuries can be avoided only when everyone has fastened their seat belts.

Turbulence avoidance is an important topic for research, and there are enough studies on North Atlantic and North Pacific routes. The relatively bump-free air experiences in future would need actionable forecasts using data on atmospheric information from many sources and artificial intelligence. A company known as 'SkyPath' is leading the studies, which integrates data from weather forecasts, satellite observations and aircraft measurements to understand and identify the regions which are likely to be impacted by turbulence. Airlines and travellers would benefit from this. Airlines can certainly use the results in optimising flight paths and minimising operational costs. The results would also be useful in working out passengers' comfort.

The airspace in the Indian sub-continent is quite critical for similar studies. The physical mechanisms causing turbulence in Indian airspace have not been studied in detail. Aviation research must focus on the region. Indian airspace faces many turbulence-generating processes: mid-latitude clear-sky jet stream shears in North India, Himalayan mountain ranges and intense tropical convective turbulence.

Convective turbulence during late summer and monsoon season in the tropical region of India is a serious concern for our airspace. Deep thunderstorms produce powerful updrafts and downdrafts. As the warmer climate holds more moisture and energy, the convective system intensifies. Further, jet streams and wind shear are also impacted by large-scale monsoon wind circulation systems. More data from flight operations in Indian airspace and climate simulations need to be studied using AI to quantify the intensity. It will help airlines to minimise their operational costs and choose optimum flight paths.

Air turbulence is the reality of the warming planet, and it must be recognised. The physical mechanisms that are enhancing the impacts and the physics behind its generation must be clearly understood. More studies and research are needed for the complete understanding of the mechanism and accurate forecasting.

The August 4th, Air India flight AI2379, after a mid-air scare due to the turbulence, landed at the destination safely. The passengers were terrified. Some of them experienced it for the first time and must have been caught off-guard when the aircraft suddenly lost 300 feet of altitude. It is necessary to understand that aircraft are built to withstand far more severe shocks than what turbulence can produce. The wings are subjected to loads far greater than what is produced by turbulence. During testing, the wings are subjected to several feet of bend to ensure that the structure has sufficient safety margin. The structural limits are tested before it is certified to be airworthy and can carry passengers. The greatest risk is the injury to unsecured people who can be thrown around the cabin and struck by loose objects. Passengers must secure themselves throughout the flight by fastening seat belts. Even when seat-belt signs are switched off, it is wiser to keep them loosely fastened.

AI: A doomsday scenario lurking in the future



DEBASISH SOM

Global capital markets have committed an unprecedented volume of capital to AI infrastructure since 2023, intensifying through 2025-26 and drawing comparisons to railway mania and the dot-com telecom overbuild. Cumulative 2022-26 investment estimates range from roughly \$1.8 trillion (Goldman Sachs) to \$2.5-2.6 trillion in total 2026 AI spending (Gartner), with infrastructure alone accounting for around \$1.4 trillion. The four largest hyperscalers - Amazon, Alphabet, Microsoft and Meta - are guiding towards roughly \$725 billion in combined 2026 capex, up 77 per cent year-on-year; including Oracle, the group approaches \$800 billion. Goldman

projects hyperscaler capex could reach \$5.3 trillion between 2025 and 2030. Capital intensity is extreme: 2026 capex runs at roughly 86 per cent of revenue for Oracle, 54 per cent for Meta, and 46-47 per cent for Microsoft and Alphabet. Realised returns lag far behind this spending. Only about 21 per cent of S&P 500 companies report measurable financial benefits from AI (Morgan Stanley), and a widely cited MIT study found that 95 per cent of generative AI pilots show no measurable profit impact. Sequoia's David Cahn estimates an annual \$600 billion revenue gap between hyperscaler infrastructure spending and actual AI ecosystem sales - a divergence already exceeding the gap seen before the 2001 telecom collapse. Combined revenue of leading AI developers, including OpenAI and Anthropic, likely totals under \$35 billion, a small fraction of hyperscaler capex. Gartner projects that over 40 per cent of agentic AI projects will be cancelled by 2027 due to unclear returns. The downstream supply chain carries uneven exposure. Chipmakers such as Nvidia, TSMC, Broadcom and Micron remain supply-constrained rather than speculative, though they are still fully exposed as direct "capex receivers". Power utilities face the risk that stranded generation investment gets socialised onto ratepayers. The most vulnerable tier is smaller, thinly capitalised cooling, packaging and construction firms, which McKinsey warns face genuine stranded-asset risk if capex decelerates.

A defining 2026 feature is the accelerating shift from cash to debt financing. Alphabet reported its first negative free cash flow quarter since its 2004 IPO. Incremental debt as a share of hyperscaler capex rose from about 9 per cent in FY2024 to roughly 32 per cent by mid-2026, pushing aggregate hyperscaler debt to about \$700 billion, with up to \$1.5 trillion in additional issuance projected. This burden is unevenly distributed: Microsoft, Alphabet, Meta and Amazon retain strong investment-grade ratings and are supplementing debt with equity, including Alphabet's record \$84.75 billion raise in June 2026. Oracle, rated just two notches above sub-investment grade, with capex at 86 per cent of revenue and concentrated exposure to OpenAI, represents the most plausible point of initial stress, with its credit default swap cost having more than tripled since September 2025. Over \$1 trillion in anticipated AI debt is expected from private credit, prompting Oliver Wyman comparisons to 2008's hidden housing-risk exposure. Most analysts treat a severe crisis as a tail risk rather than a base case. Prediction markets price an end-2026 "bubble burst" at roughly 18 per cent probability, with a moderate 20-30 per cent valuation correction seen as more likely. A typical failure pathway would begin with a monetisation shortfall or interest-rate shock. Because AI market value is concentrated in a few firms, distress at a highly exposed counterparty such as Oracle - especially if tied to an OpenAI setback - could trigger credit-spread contagion across the broader hyperscaler bond market. Illustrative severe scenarios describe unemployment above 10 per cent and equity markets falling nearly 40 per cent by 2028, with S&P Global estimating a full bust could eliminate 2.5 million jobs.

A separate risk involves a sudden efficiency breakthrough rendering current hardware-intensive infrastructure obsolete, echoing unused fibre-optic capacity after the dot-com bust. Insurers carry dual exposure: as underwriters of novel, hard-to-price data centre risk, with sites costing up to \$20 billion and often located in hail- and tornado-prone regions, and, more significantly, as creditors financing the buildout through private credit and structured securities - an arrangement Oliver Wyman likens directly to pre-2008 mortgage exposure. Other sectors face varied risks: utilities from stranded assets, commercial real estate from concentrated hyperscaler tenancy, and automakers and electronics manufacturers from rising component costs as AI absorbs semiconductor and memory supply, with memory prices having more than doubled over the past year. Moody's models a theoretical 40 per cent AI valuation correction as reducing household wealth and consumer spending, especially among high-net-worth households, with spillovers into luxury goods, real estate and advertising-dependent media.

The US government's capacity to intervene is more constrained than in 2008 or 2020. Federal interest payments are projected to reach \$1 trillion in FY2026, already exceeding defence and Medicare spending, while the government must refinance roughly \$9 trillion in maturing debt in 2026 alone. The Dallas Fed finds hyperscaler bond issuance is already crowding out other investment-grade borrowers. Any rescue would likely have to come through Federal Reserve monetary action rather than fiscal intervention, but this is itself constrained if a credit event coincides with elevated inflation - and much AI-related private credit exposure sits with non-bank entities lacking the Fed's established emergency-lending relationships. India's exposure runs through distinct channels. Its IT/BPO sector, employing 10-15 million people, is already experiencing disruption from AI's ordinary productivity effects: gross IT hiring fell from roughly 230,000 to 170,000 annually, TCS reported its first revenue decline in years, and Cognizant announced 12,000-15,000 layoffs, mostly in India. This reflects AI's demonstrated capability rather than infrastructure spending, meaning a capex slowdown would not reverse it. Separately, foreign portfolio investors withdrew record capital from Indian equities in early 2026 amid global reallocation towards AI-exposed stocks, though a deepened domestic institutional base has absorbed much of the selling. In sum, the AI investment cycle represents an unprecedented capital commitment with returns still unproven and financing increasingly reliant on debt. While most analysts see a severe crisis as a tail risk, the fiscal and monetary tools available to contain one in the US and exposed economies such as India are more limited than during previous major financial disruptions.



The writer is a retired IAS officer, IIT Kharagpur engineer, and infrastructure leader. He writes on economics, technology policy and AI investment risks



In April 2010, Dantewada in Chhattisgarh witnessed one of the deadliest Naxal attacks in Indian history, killing seventy-seven security personnel. The ambush involved IEDs, mortars, AK-47s, self-loading rifles, light machine guns, Sten guns, and grenades. This attack was one of countless attacks in that series.

I was travelling by train that day. Train compartments in India are often like mini parliaments, where strangers freely debate politics and current affairs. The incident shook us to our core, and it became the subject of discussion. While we deplored the Naxal ideology of armed struggle against democracy, we were perplexed by the sophistication of their operations. How do criminals living inside forests acquire arms and ammunition? How do they manage food, communication, intelligence, transportation, and logistics so effectively? Everyone had a theory.

Then a fellow passenger, who had introduced himself as a CA, interrupted with an interesting observation. He said that for every comrade in the jungle, there were two in the towns. According to him, while most foot soldiers are poor tribals with little education who are indoctrinated into Naxal ideology, their urban support

base includes doctors, engineers, lawyers, chartered accountants, and other professionals. They ensure that the armed cadres receive money, weapons, food, intelligence, and supplies to continue the so-called struggle. They were not merely ideological supporters. They functioned as fundraisers, procurers, suppliers, facilitators, and intellectual justifiers of the movement.

That same year, a former Home Secretary estimated the annual funding of the Naxal movement at around a thousand crores. Such money, he said, was invested in gold, fixed deposits, and real estate through sympathisers and front networks. Highlighting the challenge, he warned that the Maoists were aiming to overthrow the Indian state by 2050.

The insurgency had reached its peak in the late 2000s, when nearly 180 districts were affected by Naxals. This vast stretch became known as the "Red Corridor", with some areas effectively considered "lost" to them.



The term Naxal comes from Naxalbari in West Bengal, where a peasant uprising began in 1967 with the slogan "land to the tiller". Over the decades, however, the movement strayed far from its original objectives. In the name of the poor and tribals, it often ended up harming them instead. Rather than enabling development, Naxals frequently opposed roads, schools, hos-

sonnel killed over the years.

But one crucial aspect is often overlooked: the Naxal fighters are only cannon fodder. Interestingly, even Charu Majumdar, regarded as the father of the movement, remained its chief ideologue rather than a fighter himself. This pattern persisted; poor tribals risked their lives while urban intellectual supporters remained

safe, authoring articles and books, attending conferences, raising funds, and providing ideological justification for violence, portraying it as a revolutionary struggle.

The forests may have been cleared of armed cadres, but the ideological ecosystem can survive in intellectual and urban spaces. It can survive in intellectual circles, advocacy networks, and political discourse, waiting for circumstances that might allow it to re-emerge. When Prime Minister Narendra Modi used the phrase "Dimagi Naxals", he was pointing to this distinction.

Coming back to my train journey in 2010, the fellow passenger who had introduced us to the urban support base of the Naxals eventually confided that he was himself one such "cerebral Naxal". He was returning from an annual conference in the Red Zone. That revelation changed the conversation. Until then, we had imagined Naxals as distant figures hiding in the jungles. Sitting across from us was someone who claimed to be part of the intellectual ecosystem that supported them.

India may have won the battle, but the war remains. Insurgencies are fought on two fronts: the physical battlefield and the battle of ideas. Winning the first does not automatically mean winning the second.

The writer is an Economist

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Order Order

Delhi High Court asks FSSAI not to cancel ITC's licence

The Delhi High Court on Tuesday asked the FSSAI not to cancel for the time being ITC Ltd's licence over failure to comply with directives asking the conglomerate to remove all "100 per cent" claims in relation to its product, 'Aashirvaad MP Chakki Atta'.

Justice Swarana Kanta Sharma granted interim protection to ITC on its petition challenging the FSSAI advisories and notices to discontinue the usage of the term "100%" for its product or face suspension of FSSAI License.

"Since the issue regarding jurisdiction is to be decided and the courts will be closed, till the next date of hearing, no decision regarding cancellation of the license will be taken," Justice Sharma said as it listed the case for hearing on September 9.

Justice Sharma also said that she would pass an order on Monday, August 31, on the maintainability of a separate petition by AWL Agri Business Limited against FSSAI.

AWL Agri Business Limited received FSSAI notices over allegedly misleading label declarations and claims, including that of being "100 per cent Veg" and "Cholesterol Free – For Healthy Lifestyle", for its product, 'Fortune Soya Health Refined Soyabean Oil'. (PTI)



SC slams 45-year-long litigation in murder case

The Supreme Court has directed the release of a 70-year-old man by suspending his sentence as it termed the nearly half century long litigation in a double-murder case from Jharkhand a "failure of judicial system."

A bench of Justices JB Pardiwala and K Vinod Chandran also questioned the period of over two decades taken by the Jharkhand High Court for deciding the appeal filed by accused Simon Soren, who is undergoing treatment at hospital while in custody.

"The above case projects the failure of the judicial system, when a crime went unpunished and the accused were put to the torture of a prolonged trial of 22 years and then after conviction, the appeal filed having been dismissed after yet another two decades and two years," the bench said in its August 19 order. There was a double murder incident in Dumka in 1981. Six individuals were arrayed as accused in the case. The court noted that out of the six, two accused died before the framing of the charges and three of the four convicted, died while the appeal was pending before the High Court. "The sole remaining accused, aged about 70 and troubled with multiple ailments, has surrendered into custody after the High Court convicted him (in 2024)," it said. The court noted that Simon Soren has altogether spent only two years, four months and 12 days in custody and hence the crime has gone unpunished.

Advocate Fauzia Shakil, appearing for Simon Soren, submitted that he would suffer grave prejudice and irreparable loss if bail is not granted to him.

The bench said, "Despite the horrendous crime of a double murder, we cannot close our eyes to the ordeal suffered by the accused in the last 45 years. Especially noting his medical condition and the affidavit of the State that the petitioner is admitted in the hospital, though in custody, we suspend the sentence and direct that the petitioner shall be released forthwith on condition of his not committing any crime when on bail and on his personal surety." The bench also requisitioned the original record of the case in physical as well as digital form with a request to the High Court and the trial court to send it within four weeks. "By our earlier order, we had also directed the High Court to give us a comprehensive report as to why the trial and the disposal of the criminal appeal was delayed to such an extent. An affidavit has been filed by the registrar general of the HC, which reveals a shocking pendency of criminal appeals," it said.

The bench said the registrar general said the delay in trial was because the accused were absconding for six years, but there is no explanation for the 12 years it took for the trial to be completed when the charges were framed in the year 1991. "We also notice from report of district and sessions judge that case was transferred from one court to another, five times in 11 years after charge was framed," it remarked. (PTI)

Rajasthan HC bans junk food in school canteens, near gates, flags issues related to Gen Z, Gen Alpha

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Jodhpur

The Rajasthan High Court has banned the sale of carbonated drinks, chips and other junk food in school canteens and within 50 metres of school gates as it issued a slew of directions on balanced food and nutrition besides expressing concern over paper leaks, excessive screen time and inadequate infrastructure in rural schools.

Taking suo motu cognisance of "systemic deficiencies" in foundational institutions meant to nurture Gen Z, Gen Alpha and Gen Beta, a Jodhpur bench of Justice

Anoop Kumar Dhand directed every school to constitute a food safety and nutrition committee, display menu boards in canteens carrying information on calorie count, ingredients and nutritional value, and ensure that mid-day meals conform to balanced-diet guidelines.

The court on Monday issued notices to the Union Education and Human Resource Secretary, Union Ministry of Consumer Affairs, Food and Public Distribution, Rajasthan Chief Secretary, Additional Chief Secretary (Education), Secretary (Food and Civil Supplies), Food Safety and Standards Authority of India (FSSAI) and



SC to set up special bench to hear plea on OBC creamy-layer criteria

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Tuesday agreed to consider setting up a special bench to hear Centre's plea seeking clarification on the applicability of its March 11 judgement on OBC creamy-layer criteria to candidates of the Civil Services Examination (CSE) 2025.

The Department of Personnel and Training (DoPT) seeks directions allowing the Government to proceed with service allocation of the 958 candidates recommended by the Union Public Service Commission (UPSC) for CSE-2025 on the basis of the OBC creamy-layer determination applied before the March 11 verdict.

At the outset of day's proceedings, a bench comprising Chief Justice Surya Kant and justices Joyimalya Bagchi and V Mohana was told by Solicitor General Tushar Mehta, appearing for the Centre, that the DoPT has filed a miscellaneous application in a disposed of matter seeking some urgent directions and it has to be listed before a bench headed by Justice PS Narasimha.

Senior advocate Sanjay Hegde, appearing for a litigant, said that a bench comprising justices Narasimha and R Mahadevan had



passed the order on March 11 and the instant miscellaneous application has to be heard by the same bench as the judges sit in different combinations now.

"We will have to set up a special bench," the CJI said, adding that he will speak with the judges and set up the bench.

The DoPT's plea arises from the top court's judgement in a case titled as Union of India vs Rohith Nathan, in which the court, on March 11 held, among other things, that the October 14, 2004 clarifying letter could not override the September 8, 1993 office memorandum governing identification of the OBC creamy layer.

The court also held that the salary or income of a parent employed in a public sector undertaking or the private sector could not by

itself be treated as the determinative criterion for creamy-layer exclusion.

The status and category of the parent's post, along with the prescribed income/wealth test, were to be considered in accordance with the 1993 office memorandum.

The Government, while stating that it is bound by the Supreme Court's ruling, has said that applying the judgement mechanically to CSE-2025 could result in unequal treatment of candidates who were similarly placed but acted differently based on the legal position prevailing when the examination was conducted.

According to the application, the CSE-2025 notification was issued on January 22, 2025, the preliminary examination was held on May 25, 2025, and the main examination was conducted from August 22 to 31.

The UPSC declared the final result on March 6, 2026, recommending 958 candidates for appointment to the IAS, IFS, IPS and other central services.

The top court delivered the Rohith Nathan judgement just five days later, on March 11.

The Centre has pointed out that candidates whose parents were employed in PSUs or the private sector and whose income exceeded the prescribed ceiling could, under the interpretation prevailing at the time, have considered themselves ineligible for OBC (non-creamy layer) benefits.

Some such candidates, the application says, may consequently have contested CSE-2025 only in the general category, while others may not have applied under the OBC category at all.

They may also have foregone benefits such as the three-year upper age relaxation and additional attempts available to OBC (non-creamy layer) candidates.

The Government said that candidates who had applied under the OBC category but were subsequently found ineligible could potentially benefit from a fresh assessment in light of the March 11 judgement.

SC directs Tejpal to surrender within 3 weeks, rejects plea for exemption

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Tuesday directed journalist Tarun Tejpal to surrender within three weeks to undergo his 10-year prison sentence in a 2013 rape case in which he was convicted by the Bombay High Court.

A bench of Justice Alok Aradhe dismissed Tejpal's plea seeking exemption from surrendering.

"The application seeking exemption from surrendering is rejected. However, the appellant (Tejpal) is granted three weeks' time to surrender and file surrender certificate before this court," the bench said in its order.

The apex court listed his appeal challenging his conviction and sentence for hearing on September 22, subject to the filing of the surrender certificate.

"In case the surrender certificate is filed on or before September 21, 2026, the reg-

istry shall list the criminal appeal for hearing on September 22, 2026 before the regular court," it said.

Tejpal, former editor of Tehelka, was convicted of raping a junior colleague inside a hotel elevator in 2013 during an event organised by the magazine in Goa. Earlier, the 62-year-old journalist had claimed that he was a political victim.

On August 6, the High Court convicted Tejpal of rape and sentenced him to rigorous imprisonment for 10 years, overturning his acquittal by the trial court five years ago.

During the hearing on Tuesday, senior advocate Kapil Sibal, appearing for Tejpal, said the incident was of 2013 and the journalist had earlier spent around six months in jail in the case.

"He (Tejpal) has throughout been on bail since then. The High Court has directed him to surrender within four weeks. This court may fix the main appeal for hearing



on August 31," he said.

Solicitor General Tushar Mehta, appearing for the Goa Government, said the High Court has given him four weeks to surrender only to enable him to file an appeal and application for exemption from surrendering before the apex court.

"Merit is a relevant consideration in this case. It is a 10-year sentence for aggravated rape," the top law officer said.

Countering Mehta's sub-

missions, Sibal said, "It is not a rape at all".

"How much time do you (Tejpal) need to surrender?" the bench asked Sibal and senior advocate Aman Lekhi, who also appeared for Tejpal.

Sibal urged the bench to list the main appeal for hearing as early as possible.

Tejpal's plea was listed in chamber matters, where cases are taken up for preliminary or procedural directions and then placed before a regular bench for hearing.

HC quashes sacking of 48 assistant managers of Uttar Pradesh Cooperative Bank

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Lucknow

The Allahabad High Court on Tuesday quashed the June 2019 orders terminating the service of 48 assistant managers appointed in the Uttar Pradesh Cooperative Bank in 2016 and directed that they be permitted to resume duties on their respective posts.

Justice Rajeev Singh of the Lucknow bench passed the order while allowing separate petitions filed by Manish Kumar and 47 others, observing that an employee's services cannot be terminated merely on the recommendation or direction of another authority and the appointing authority must independently examine the matter and decide.

The counsel for the petitioners had argued that the bank's management committee issued the termination

orders on the basis of direction issued by the Principal Secretary, Cooperative Department, and did not attribute any individual illegal act or misconduct to the petitioners.

The recruitment process for assistant managers initiated in 2015 was plagued by controversies. Initially, candidates were required to possess graduation degrees in certain specified subjects. Subsequently, with the approval of the competent authority, the eligibility criterion was modified to graduation in any subject with a minimum of 50 per cent marks.

A revised advertisement was issued on July 22, 2015. The petitioners were selected thereafter on the basis of a written examination and interview. An unsuccessful candidate, however, challenged the selection process before the High Court.



On August 24, the apex court said it would consider Tejpal's plea seeking exemption from surrendering on Tuesday.

In its August 24 order, the bench had referred to the court's 2006 decision in the Mayuram Subramanian Srinivasan vs CBI case and said it is mandatory to surrender before the appeal is to be heard.

"Therefore, until and unless suitable orders are passed on the application seeking exemption from surrender, the appeal cannot be listed before the court. Therefore, the prayer made to list the matter before the court without considering the application seeking exemption from surrender cannot be accepted," the bench said.

On August 20, Tejpal moved the top court challenging the August 6 order of the High Court against his conviction in the case.

Earlier, the Goa Government moved the top

court seeking an enhanced sentence for the former editor of Tehelka, contending that the case warranted imprisonment for life. In its petition filed in the apex court, the Goa Government has contended that the sentence imposed by the High Court is grossly disproportionate to the nature and gravity of the offences committed by Tejpal.

In its 81-page judgment, the High Court had termed the trial court's 2021 order "perverse", noting that it fell for the notion that a sexual assault complainant must be a "perfect victim" and should conduct herself in a certain way so as to appear credible.

The High Court also expressed strong disapproval of the way the defence put the victim in the dock and focused on her personal life, and said it found it surprising that the trial court "remained silent and allowed the defence to harass and humiliate her during the cross-examination".

SC refuses to hear plea against demolition of lawyers' chambers near Lucknow court

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Tuesday refused to entertain a plea challenging an order related to the demolition of lawyers' chambers allegedly constructed by encroaching public land near the Lucknow District Court complex.

"The demolition has to take place," a bench of justices Vikram Nath and Sandeep Mehta said.

After the bench showed disinclination to entertain the plea, the counsel for the petitioner withdrew it.

"I have seen it myself. I was there for two years as a senior judge. I know what kind of



constructions are there," Justice Nath, who had earlier served as a judge of the Allahabad High Court, said.

The petitioner's counsel suggested that the matter be referred to mediation.

The bench, which refused to refer the matter to mediation, permitted the counsel to withdraw the plea, which challenged an August 4 order of the Lucknow bench of the Allahabad High Court.

Better half becomes bitter half in marriage if issues not resolved between spouses: HC

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The institution of marriage is quite paradoxical and if the issues between spouses are not resolved quickly, the better half becomes a bitter half, the Delhi High Court has observed.

The High Court said one of the most beautiful relationships of humans, that of a husband and wife, becomes one of the most terrible when things go wrong in a matrimonial alliance.

Justice Vimal Kumar Yadav made the observations while allowing a man's appeal against a trial court's judgment sentencing him to three years of imprisonment



for trying to kill his wife by pouring Baygon spray in her mouth.

The High Court acquitted Nafe Singh in the case, saying the prosecution's case lacked cogent evidence about the intention and knowledge as contemplated in Section 307 of the IPC.

It is highly unsafe to act upon the kind of shaky evi-

dence brought on record, the court said while granting the benefit of doubt to the man.

The High Court, in its August 24 verdict, said, "The institution of marriage is quite paradoxical and a world of extremities. The best, in no time, becomes worst if not handled carefully. The better-half becomes the bitter-half if issues are not taken care of and resolved as soon as possible."

It further said, "One of the most beautiful relationships of humans, that is of a husband and wife, becomes one of the most terrible when things go wrong in a matrimonial alliance.

our Nation) and beyond, on the other hand, the foundational institutions meant to nurture them, particularly the Government schools in rural and village areas continue to suffer from systemic deficiencies," the court said in the order.

It said students currently studying in schools, colleges and universities across the nation and the state, especially in Government schools situated in urban or rural and village areas, where they study in primary, upper-primary and secondary schools belong to the "Generation Alpha"; the newly born babies, ie. "Generation Beta", who are supposed to

get admission in nursery and primary schools soon; and the students studying in colleges and universities belong to the "Generation Z".

"In short these three generations are the ones who are going to be leading the nation in coming future," the order said.

The court banned the sale of high-fat, high-sugar and high-salt (HFSS) food items in school canteens and within 50 metres of school gates. The prohibited items include carbonated drinks, chips, trans-fat-containing bakery products and other junk food. The court directed every school to constitute a food safety and nutrition commit-

tee within four weeks, comprising teachers, parents and student representatives. Details of the committees are to be uploaded on the education department's website.

Within eight weeks, school canteens will also have to display menu boards carrying information on the calorie count, ingredients and nutritional value of food items, besides implementing a traffic-light labelling system.

The state Government has been asked to file an affidavit within six weeks detailing steps taken to implement the 2020 regulations on safe and balanced food in

Government, aided and private schools. The court further directed that mid-day meals and other nutrition schemes conform to FSSAI's balanced-diet guidelines. A dedicated portal and helpline are also to be established for complaints regarding violations of food-safety norms.

The bench expressed concern over increasing mobile screen time among children and the excessive dependence on technology. While recognising that AI and digital learning are essential for preparing students for global competition, it cautioned that technology should not replace fundamental learning skills.

INTERVIEW



Technical skill falls short on its own today. As AI changes how we work, universities must teach emotional strength and ethics. Combining timeless Indian wisdom with modern tools creates clear-headed leaders ready for real-world pressure



You often speak about mind management as an essential life skill. Should mind management and emotional wellbeing become a formal part of higher

Can education build minds that technology cannot replace?

“Technology can transform industries, but it cannot replace sound judgement,” says Swami Mukundananda, Founder and Chairman of Jagadguru Kripalu University, in a conversation with *The Pioneer*, highlighting why education must build resilient minds alongside technological skills

As education becomes increasingly driven by AI, technology and employability, what do you believe is missing from the way we prepare young people for the future of work? How can universities ensure that students develop not only technical competence but also clarity of thought, emotional resilience, ethical judgement and the ability to make meaningful decisions?

While our education system has built technical expertise, it has not invested equally in developing emotionally resilient and ethically grounded individuals. Technology can transform industries, but it cannot replace sound judgement or the ability to manage one's mind. Universities must nurture resilience, adaptability, creativity and lifelong learning alongside technical skills. Students should also develop ethical decision-making frameworks to navigate situations where technology alone cannot provide the right answers.

education? If so, what could universities realistically do to help students manage stress, anxiety, distractions and the pressure to constantly compete and succeed?

Mind management is a core life skill because technical knowledge is effective only when the mind is balanced. Universities should integrate structured programmes focused on emotional intelligence, self-awareness, mindfulness, mentorship and reflection. Students must learn to manage distractions, peer pressure and setbacks while measuring progress through personal growth rather than comparison with others. Such an approach prepares them to thrive both personally and professionally.

Jagadguru Kripalu University seeks to bring together contemporary, industry-relevant education and India's knowledge traditions. How do you envision this integration working in the classroom without making traditional knowledge merely an additional subject, but instead making it relevant to how students think, learn and solve modern problems?

Indian knowledge traditions should enrich the way students think rather than exist as stand-alone subjects. Concepts from Yoga, the Bhagavad Gita and Ayurveda can offer valuable perspectives on leadership, ethics, wellbeing and decision-making while complementing modern education. Combined with interdisciplinary learning, experiential projects and industry collaboration, this approach enables students to solve real-world challenges with technical expertise, contextual understanding and social responsibility.

Teachers today are dealing with a generation that has grown up with smartphones, social media, AI tools and unprecedented access to information. What should fundamentally change in the role of a teacher from being a provider of knowledge to becoming a mentor, guide and

facilitator of deeper thinking?

AI can provide information instantly, but it cannot develop wisdom or values. The teacher's role must therefore evolve from delivering knowledge to nurturing discernment, critical thinking and ethical responsibility. By encouraging students to question, evaluate and apply information thoughtfully, teachers help them make conscious choices and use technology in ways that benefit society. Their greatest contribution is shaping character, not just careers.

There is growing concern that higher education is becoming too focused on degrees, placements and starting salaries. What, in your view, should universities do to help students define success beyond a job title or salary package and develop a stronger sense of purpose and social responsibility?

Employability is important, but success should not be measured solely by salary or designation. Universities should encourage self-discovery, community engagement and purposeful careers by helping students align their strengths with meaningful contributions. Career guidance must also focus on values, impact and service, enabling students to understand that fulfillment comes from creating value for society, not merely accumulating achievements.

You have addressed students and professionals at leading institutions and organisations across India and abroad. What differences, if any, have you observed in the concerns and aspirations of young people today? And what is one quality you believe every student should consciously develop to remain relevant and grounded in a rapidly changing world?



Across geographies, young people seek meaningful work, continuous growth and a fulfilling life. In a rapidly changing world, the most important quality is learning agility – the willingness to continuously learn, unlearn and relearn. Universities can cultivate this through interdisciplinary learning, industry exposure, experiential education and regular reflection, ensuring graduates remain adaptable and future-ready.

Looking ahead to India's ambition of becoming a developed nation by 2047, what kind of educational transformation do you believe is most urgent? What should universities, educators and policymakers prioritise today if India is to create not just a skilled workforce, but a generation capable of responsible leadership and nation-building?

To realise the vision of Viksit Bharat 2047, education must shift from degree acquisition to capability building. Universities should emphasise problem-solving, creativity, entrepreneurship, collaboration and experiential learning through stronger industry partnerships. At the same time, technological progress must remain rooted in ethics, responsibility and India's civilisational values. By combining innovation with character, education can nurture leaders who contribute not only to economic growth but also to a more inclusive, sustainable and purpose-driven nation.

Should assessment change when students have access to generative AI?

JYOTSNA SINGH
Campus Director and Professor, NMIMS

The widespread availability of generative AI tools such as ChatGPT is changing how students learn, research, and complete academic work. As a result, traditional assessment methods need to evolve rather than simply trying to prevent students from using AI.

First, assessments should focus more on critical thinking, application, and problem-solving rather than memorisation. AI can quickly generate definitions, summaries, and standard answers, so questions should require students to analyse information, justify decisions, solve unfamiliar problems, or apply concepts to real-world situations.

Second, educators should consider process-based assessment. Instead of evaluating only a final submission, teachers can assess drafts, research notes, reflections, presentations, and discussions. This provides insight into how students developed their ideas and makes learning more important than simply producing a polished final answer.



Oral assessments and classroom discussions can also become more valuable. Asking students to explain, defend, or critique their work allows educators to evaluate whether they genuinely understand the subject. Short viva-style assessments can complement written assignments.

At the same time, students should not necessarily be prohibited from using AI. Instead, assessments can teach responsible and transparent AI use. Students could be asked to use AI for brainstorming or feedback and then identify its limita-

tions, verify its information, and explain how they improved the AI-generated output. This develops AI literacy, which is increasingly important in higher education and the workplace.

Finally, assessment should become more authentic and personalised. Projects connected to students' experiences, local communities, current issues, or practical workplace situations are harder to complete

through generic AI-generated responses and provide stronger evidence of individual understanding.

In conclusion, generative AI does not make assessment less important—it makes better assessment necessary. The goal should shift from detecting whether students used AI to evaluating what students understand, how they think, and how responsibly they use technology. Assessments should therefore measure reasoning, creativity, communication, application, and the learning process alongside knowledge.



Reimagining legal education for a profession in perpetual evolution

CHINMAY DESHMUKH

Professor, BITS Law School

There is a tendency, particularly since the arrival of AI, to speak of the legal profession as being on the verge of fundamental transformation. But lawyers have heard versions of this story before. The technology may be new; the underlying question—how law should respond when society changes around it—certainly is not.

Law has always had to balance stability and change. Contracts, property, institutions and everyday decisions depend on some confidence about what the rules are. At the same time, a legal system that cannot respond to changes in the society around it will quickly become obsolete. Holmes's famous observation that “the life of the law has not been logic: it has been experience” was, among other things, a recognition of this fact.

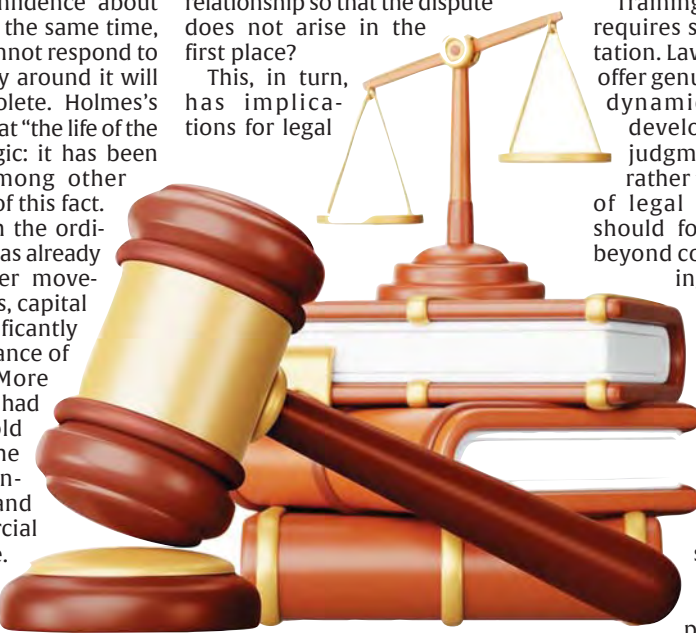
Think of how much the ordinary work of lawyers has already changed. Cross-border movement of people, goods, capital and services has significantly increased the importance of transnational law. More recently, lawyers have had to work out how old concepts apply to the internet, blockchain-based transactions, and even private commercial activity in outer space.

So, change is not new, but what is striking today is the

pace of change and its multi-layered character. Consider the regulation of an online platform. It may simultaneously involve contract, competition, privacy and constitutional law. Consequently, a lawyer may need to understand the underlying technology, incentive structures on the platform, and why and how users behave the way they do.

A good lawyer should certainly be able to answer the question: what happens if this dispute reaches court? But increasingly, the more useful question may be: how can we structure this relationship so that the dispute does not arise in the first place?

This, in turn, has implications for legal



education. The goal should not be to turn law students into amateur economists, data scientists or climate scientists. But they should know enough to understand what those experts are telling them, recognise the legal consequences of a design choice, and know which questions to ask. They will still have to decide whether the cases retrieved by an AI are actually relevant, understand what an argument is really doing, read between the lines, identify the interests at stake, and judge what advice makes sense for a client in their particular context.

Training students in these skills requires some room for experimentation. Law schools should be able to offer genuinely interdisciplinary and dynamic clinical courses, and develop assessments that test judgment and problem-solving rather than only the reproduction of legal knowledge. Internships should focus on gaining exposure beyond courts and law firms, including in technology, finance, policy and civil society.

The task, ultimately, is not to prepare students for every technological or professional change that might come their way. It is to educate lawyers who can recognise change, understand enough of the world around law to make sense of it, and exercise sound judgement when the familiar boundaries of their profession begin to shift.

How placements are changing in Indian universities: Beyond CGPAs and mass hiring

PRAVEEN K PULA

Founder and Chancellor, Woxsen University

For a very long time, placement season was one of the biggest events on any Indian campus during the end semesters. Since the last decade, the whole gamut of placement has been consistently changing as new-age recruiters have started to look past a student's CGPA. Even a few years ago, a good CGPA would qualify a student as a strong candidate. However, as the jobs evolve, companies are looking for students who have solved problems, built something of their own, and made decisions that could ideally impact a business for good. Inevitably, placement season is no longer a year-end activity. Placement outcomes in Indian universities are now a culmination of innovation, entrepreneurship, decision-making, skill-building alongside academic excellence. Another biggest shift in the Indian placement scenario is the gradual but visible decline in mass hiring. Concentration of a large chunk of offers from a few specific big companies used to be the norm and somehow was a yardstick of success. However, modern recruiters are looking for candidates who already understand the specific domain (management, technology, design, etc.) and adapt to workplace change without ham-

pering the business process. With AI & other emerging technologies becoming an integral part of workplace change, Indian universities are inevitably shifting towards an inter-disciplinary module and application-based learning. As the placement trend is moving away from mass hiring to a skill-first one, Indian universities are prioritising specialisation from day one, unlike the traditional practice of keeping it for the end. For instance, at Woxsen University, we have been working with a continuous, global, and learning outcome-based model over the traditional placement mode. This early-exposure strategy is paired with deep academic-corporate partnerships that directly integrate industry leaders into curriculum design, creating exclusive pre-placement interaction pipelines that bypass standard, generic mass-hiring filters.

This is why the focus is shifting from what to think to how to think. Critical thinking, logical reasoning, adaptability and inter-disciplinary fluency are no



longer soft add-ons; they are the base a technical degree sits on. Institutions are building these habits in from day one, not saving them for the final semester before placements.

Moreover, the very basis of placement has changed globally, including Indian campuses. Universities are imbibing industry experience and exposure, real consulting projects, mentorships from industry experts and innovation push as parts of the daily learning process. The World Economic Forum's

(WEF) Future of Jobs Report 2025 found seven in ten employers now rank analytical thinking as the top core skill. Deloitte's State of AI in the Enterprise 2026 report found insufficient worker skills, not budget or technology, is the biggest barrier to AI adoption. Roles like prompt engineering, AI governance and human-AI collaboration did not exist five years ago and are now standard hiring lines.

To keep pace with evolving market demands, universities are increasingly adopting tech-driven specialisations and encouraging global mobility among students. Training now takes place on advanced, real-world infrastructure. At our campus, for instance, students work inside a Bloomberg Lab equipped with live market data, alongside dedicated AI and ML studios. This shift has also helped reduce employer onboarding time, as students entering the workforce are already familiar with real industry environments. In fact, this kind of hands-on, industry-aligned learning has become the new standard across Indian universities.

To meet shifting market demands, Woxsen focuses heavily on tech-infused specialisation and global mobility. Students train in advanced, practical infrastructures like on-campus Bloomberg Labs and AI/ML studios, which minimises employer onboarding time and drives high placement

metrics, such as a recent ₹28 LPA highest package for MBAs and 24 LPA for B Tech cohorts. Furthermore, by securing prestigious EFMD global accreditations and partnering with over 175 international universities, Woxsen provides students with global immersion programmes and international research pathways that appeal directly to multinational corporations and Fortune 500 recruiters. Technology has changed the process itself. AI tools now screen resumes, conduct first-round interviews, and even assess coding skills before a human recruiter gets involved. Students need to be prepared for this reality, not just for the final interview but for every automated filter that comes before it.

Finally, students today are asking different questions. They want to know about growth paths and the kind of work they will do, not just the salary number. This is a healthy shift. It pushes universities and companies to think about long-term development, not a one-time transaction. Placements will always matter; they are proof that learning has real value outside college. But the old model, a single event at the end of four years, is fading. The new model is continuous, skill-driven and personal. Universities that adapt will produce graduates who are genuinely prepared for the world of work.

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Tata Steel gets interim relief in ₹1,755 crore demand notice

Tata Steel has received interim relief in the ₹1,755-crore demand notice issued by the Jharkhand Government, according to a regulatory filing.

The company has challenged a ₹1,755 crore mining demand notice issued by the District Mining Office, Ramgarh, Jharkhand, over alleged excess coal extraction of 16.24 million tonnes at the West Bokaro Colliery, beyond permissible limits, during 2000-01 to 2006-07.

The company was of the view that the demand lacked justification and substantive basis and had merit to challenge the demand. Accordingly, in April, Tata Steel had filed a Revision Application before the revisional authority of the coal ministry, challenging the demand notice. The Revisional Authority heard the revision application. The company hereby informs that the Revisional Authority has, inter alia, passed the following directions: the Revision Application filed by Tata Steel Ltd has been admitted for consideration. (PTI)

Rupee rises 24 paise to close at 95.46 against US dollar

The rupee pared initial losses and settled for the day higher by 24 paise at 95.46 (provisional) against the US dollar on Tuesday, driven by positive domestic markets, a weaker greenback, and a fall in crude oil prices.

Forex traders said the overall weakness in the US dollar on declining odds of a rate hike may support the rupee at lower levels. The USD/INR pair remained largely range-bound around 95.50-96.00, with oil prices and the Reserve Bank of India's intervention likely to remain the key near-term drivers, they added.

At the interbank foreign exchange, the rupee opened at 95.74, then touched an intraday high of 95.40 and finally settled for the day at 95.46 (provisional) against the greenback, higher by 24 paise from its previous close.

On Monday, the rupee settled with a marginal gain of 1 paise at 95.70 against the US dollar. (PTI)

Gold jumps ₹2,700 to ₹1.67 lakh/10g in four-day surge

Extending its winning streak for the fourth consecutive session, gold appreciated by ₹2,700 to ₹1,67,100 per 10 grams in the national Capital on Tuesday. The yellow metal of 99.9 per cent purity had closed at ₹1,64,400 per 10 grams on Monday. However, silver took a breather after its three-session rally, with traders booking profits. The white metal declined by ₹3,500 to ₹2,50,000 per kilogram (inclusive of all taxes) from the previous close of ₹2,53,500 per kg, according to the All India Sarafa Association. (PTI)

Govt infrastructure projects see cost overrun of ₹3.4 lakh crore

A total of 1,775 ongoing infrastructure projects across 17 Central Ministries/ Departments were monitored, and it was found that the total revised cost was ₹37,10,642 crore compared to their original cost of ₹33,70,138 crore.

The Pioneer

NEW DELHI | WEDNESDAY | AUGUST 26, 2026

India's freebie economy: When welfare becomes a fiscal ponzi

GOVIND BHATTACHARJEE

Government welfare schemes are certainly not Ponzi, which literally requires new investors' money to pay earlier investors. Governments possess taxation powers and can legitimately borrow against future revenues. But when political commitments made purely for electoral purposes lead to recurring expenditure with insufficient recurring revenues that compel a state to borrow recklessly, the distinction tends to get blurred. Government must provide subsidies to the needy, but when a subsidy becomes an unconditional entitlement with little measurable developmental return, freebies deviate from genuine welfare. They also crowd out growth-enhancing capital expenditure. Without careful targeting, sunset clauses, transparent subsidy accounting, outcome-based transfers, and stronger fiscal rules, it becomes a one-way journey toward financial bankruptcy for reasons of political economy. Besides, once a benefit is given, withdrawing it becomes politically impossible, producing a ratchet effect in which moving upward is easy but moving down becomes difficult.

The Economic Survey 2025-26 noted that unconditional cash transfers (UCTs) have expanded rapidly across states and now form a growing share of their welfare spending. States spent ₹1.7 lakh crore on UCTs during FY26, and the number of States implementing them has increased more than fivefold between FY23 and FY26, with half of the states running deficits in their revenue accounts. They now account for 1.25 per cent of state GDPs and 8.26 per cent of state budgets. Competitive populism today is transforming welfare into an entitlement treadmill with every election, the baseline moves up, while the revenues needed to finance it remain uncertain. Eventually, it becomes a redistribution financed by future taxpayers. In West Bengal, the BJP has raised the UCTs for women (Annapurna scheme) to ₹3000 per month from the TMS's ₹1500 (₹1700 for SC/ST). It's unlikely that any future Government would reduce the amount.

It is not that UCTs are always useless. The Economic Survey itself cites a study highlight-

ing that UCTs constitute 40-50 per cent of the monthly per capita consumption expenditure (MPCE) for at least half of the rural population in seven States. For female casual and self-employed workers, they constitute significant shares of their monthly income. The question confronting us today is when does legitimate social protection cease to be welfare and become fiscally unsustainable populism? A subsidy may be expensive but politically defensible despite the economic distortion it causes. But it becomes indefensible only when the social return on the marginal rupee spent on it falls below the return available from alternative uses of that rupee. In other words, the question that we should ask is: "Does the next ₹10,000 crore spent on the Annapurna scheme generate greater social value than the next ₹10,000 crore spent on health, education, infrastructure, or employment creation?"

Freebies today have become so deeply embedded in our political economy that it is unrealistic to expect any more PILs or media campaigns to reverse the increasing competitive populism between political parties. A pragmatic course, therefore, would be to make them fiscally responsible and socially productive instead of wasting our energies to eliminate them. Several states are facing deep fiscal stress due to these, which are impacting their growth. States spend over 60% of their revenue expenditure on salary, pension, interest payments, and subsidies; many are financing their revenue deficits through borrowing, further curtailing the scope of growth-enhancing capex. Every freebie announced

before an election is a committed expenditure that creates new permanent spending commitments without establishing permanent revenue streams to finance them. While the political dividends from them are immediate, the fiscal cost of financing them through borrowing is dispersed over the future. The risk gets multiplied when Governments resort to off-budget borrowings to conceal their true cost. A welfare state becomes fiscally dangerous when today's politicians promise benefits whose costs are to be borne by tomorrow's taxpayers, and the future capital investments that would make tomorrow's economy richer are sacrificed to finance today's political competition. It is nothing but a Ponzi-like fiscal dynamic. Hence, every political party must justify the cost of such subsidies.

A subsidy may be socially defensible when the benefits it generates, like higher incomes, better health, reduced vulnerability, etc., are greater than its direct fiscal costs and the opportunity cost of the public resources committed to it. When the recurring fiscal cost of maintaining the benefit exceeds the additional social value it generates, particularly when financed by borrowing, it becomes problematic. This can be integrated into a simple Net Social Value (NSV) framework by defining NSV = Present value of measurable social benefits – Present value of fiscal costs – Opportunity cost of displaced public expenditure. A positive NSV would be a necessary condition for a promised subsidy, but the state must still possess the recurring revenue capacity to finance it without undermining fiscal stability or resorting to borrow-

ing. Every major recurring subsidy promised in an election manifesto must therefore be accompanied by a standardised fiscal and social-impact statement covering at least six parameters: targeting, fiscal cost and non-debt financing mechanism, opportunity cost, net social return, sunset clause, and evaluation. Political parties should have no ground to object to such an architecture. The question is one of enforcement, and we have already travelled some distance in this direction.

In 2013, in the S Subramaniam Balaji v State of Tamil Nadu case, the Supreme Court held that promises of freebies made by political parties were not "corrupt practices" under the Representation of the People Act, 1951, while observing that freebies can influence voters and "shake the root of free and fair elections." It directed the Election Commission of India (ECI) to frame suitable guidelines for political parties. The ECI subsequently incorporated manifesto-related provisions into the Model Code of Conduct. However, these guidelines were relatively weak; they required parties to explain the rationale for promises and indicate broadly how they proposed to finance them, but there was no effective mechanism for verifying the fiscal claims or enforcing the promises. In 2022, the ECI proposed a standardised disclosure proforma for election promises to all political parties, requiring them to provide information to voters on the physical coverage and financial implications of each promised scheme, the proposed sources/methods of financing, and the likely implications for fiscal sustainability of the Government. Parties naturally objected, arguing that deciding Government expenditure was an issue for the electorate and the political process, not the ECI. ECI, nevertheless, introduced the proforma which remained on paper only, as there was no enforcement architecture under which a party could be disqualified or penalised for non-compliance. Subsequently, the ECI itself maintained that it could not regulate the substance of Government policy.

This is where the next reform should begin. The Supreme Court and the ECI now need to revive that mechanism that has remained a non-starter so far and make it mandatory for the parties to follow the fiscal and social impact statement as discussed above. This may fundamentally change the existing political calculus and move the parties towards fiscal accountability.

The author, a former Director General of the CAG of India, is a visiting professor at IIM Calcutta

Sensex, Nifty close higher on late buying, falling oil

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

Benchmark stock indices Sensex and Nifty pared intraday losses to close higher on Tuesday, driven by buying in the final hour amid a sharp drop in crude oil prices.

After moving in a range with a negative bias for most of the day, the 30-share BSE Sensex settled higher by 286.98 points, or 0.37 per cent, at 77,656.09. As many as 24 of its constituents ended in gains, and six in losses. During

the day, it hit a high of 77,666.39 and a low of 77,125.91.

The 50-share NSE Nifty also remained volatile before ending higher by 115.50 points, or 0.48 per cent, at 24,334.55 on lag-end buying.

Among the 30 Sensex firms, InterGlobe Aviation, Adani

Ports, Infosys, Trent, Titan and State Bank of India were the major winners.

Eternal, HCL Tech, Power Grid and Bajaj Finserv were among the major laggards. Brent crude, the global oil benchmark, declined 3 per cent to \$89.32 per barrel.

"The much-anticipated US

sanctions against Iran fell short of market expectations, causing crude oil prices and bond yields to moderate from their recent peaks. This relief in energy costs aided a moderately positive close today on the monthly expiry day," Vinod Nair, Head of Research, Geojit Investments Limited, said.

SBI

STATE BANK OF INDIA

E-AUCTION SALE NOTICE

BRANCH OFFICE: HOME LOAN CENTRE EAST DELHI (15811), UNITY ONE MALL, FIRST FLOOR, CBD, SHAHDARA, DELHI-110032

NOTICE FOR E-AUCTION SALE ON 29.09.2026 FOR MOVABLE PROPERTY

E-Auction Sale Notice for Sale of Movable Assets under the Securitization and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 read with proviso to Rule 8(6) of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002. Notice is hereby given to the public in general and in particular to the Borrower(s) and Guarantor(s) that the below described movable property hypothecated /charged to the Secured Creditor, the physical possession of which has been taken by the Authorized Officer State Bank of India, the Secured Creditor, will be sold on "As is Where is", "As is What is" and "Whatever there is" on 29.09.2026, for recovery of bank due to the secured creditor as under:-

Interested bidder may deposit Pre-Bid EMD with BAANKNET before the close of e-Auction. Credit of Pre-Bid EMD shall be given to the bidder only after receipt of payment in BAANKNET's Bank Account and up-dation of such information in the e-auction website. This may take some time as per banking process and hence bidders, in their own interest, are advised to submit the pre-bid EMD amount well in advance to avoid any last minute problem.

Date / Time of E-Auction on 29.09.2026 for 6 Hours from 10:00 AM to 04:00 PM with unlimited extn. of 10 minute each.

For Vehicle Inspection Please Contact: Mr. Amit Kumar - 9205101634 (M/s. Pehchan Professional Services Pvt. Ltd.)

S. No.	Name of the Borrower(s) / Guarantor(s)	Outstanding Dues for Recovery of which Property /ies is/ are being Sold	Vehicle Description	Reserve Price (Rs.) (below which property could not be sold) Earned Money (EMD) 10% of the Reserve Price Bid Increment Amount	Authorised Officer & Contact Person
1.	Mrs. Tanya Raj W/o Mr. Sahil Sharma Car Loan A/c. No. 40588492765 H. No.85/40 B, Gali No.4, Near Reliance Fresh, Chander Nagar, Krishna Nagar, East Delhi-110051.	Rs.2,09,918.00 as on 18.11.2025 plus future Interest and other Charges etc. thereon	Make & Model: MARUTI SWIFT DZIRE VXI Maruti Suzuki India Ltd. Regn. No.: DL14CF6166 Regn. Date: 19.11.2021 Engine No.: K12NP4042741 Chassis No.: MBHCZF35MJ156330 Colour: Metallic Premium Silver	₹ 4,48,400.00 ₹ 45,000.00 ₹ 1,000.00 (Including 18% GST As Applicable)	Chief Manager HLC East Delhi (15811), CBD, Shahdara, Delhi-110032 Mr. Amit Kumar 9205101634 (Resolution Agent)

Last Date of EMD Deposit on or before 29.09.2026 upto 09:00 AM Account/ Wallet in which EMD to be remitted :- Bidder's own wallet Registered with BAANKNET on its e-auction site: <https://baanknet.com/eauction-psb/eproc-listing> by means of NEFT/RTGS. EMD of Reserve Price to be transferred by bidders by means of challan generated on his/her/their bidder account maintained with BAANKNET on its e-auction site: <https://baanknet.com/eauction-psb/eproc-listing> by means of NEFT from his/her/their bank. For any assistance, please call please call BAANKNET HELPDESK: +91 8291220220, support.BAANKNET@psballiance.com and/or Authorized Officer.

TERMS AND CONDITIONS OF THE E-AUCTION ARE AS UNDER:
(1) E-Auction is being held on "As is where is", "as is what is basis" and "whatever there is basis" and will be conducted "On Line". The auction will be conducted through the Bank's approved service provider BAANKNET at their web portal: <https://baanknet.com/eauction-psb/eproc-listing>
(2) Bank shall reserve the right to cancel/postpone the auction.
(3) The Vehicle are available for inspection on 27.09.2026 from 11:00 AM to 4:00 PM, Contact: Mr. Amit Kumar - 9205101634 (Resolution Agent) and (Mr. Shashi, Mobile: 8979287749, SBI, Manager NPA)
(4) Successful bidder to pay GST as applicable on the successful bid amount, viz sale value.
(5) To the best of knowledge and information of the Authorized Officer there is no encumbrance on the property/ies. However the intending bidder should make their own independent inquiries regarding the encumbrances, title of the property/ies put on auction and claims/tights/dues/affecting the property prior to submitting their bid.
The e-Auction Advertisement does not constitute and will not be deemed to constitute any commitment or any representation of the Bank. The property is being sold with all the existing and future encumbrances whether known or unknown to the bank. The Authorized Officer shall not be responsible in any way for any third party claims/rights/ dues.
(6) The Earnest Money Deposit (EMD) of the successful bidder shall be retained towards part sale consideration and the EMD of the unsuccessful bidders shall be refunded. The Earnest Money Deposit shall not bear any Interest. The successful bidder shall have to deposit 25% of the sale price, immediately on acceptance of bid price by the Authorized Officer and the balance of the sale price on or before 15th day of the sale. Default in deposit of amount by the successful bidder would entail forfeiture of the whole money already deposited and property shall be put to the e-auction and the defaulting bidder shall have no claim/right in respect of property / amount.
(7) For detailed terms and conditions of the sale please refer to the link at the Bank's Service Provider's web portal: <https://baanknet.com/eauction-psb/eproc-listing> & e-auction website: <https://BAANKNET.com>
Date: 25.08.2026 Place: New Delhi Authorized Officer, State Bank of India, Home Loan Centre, East Delhi, Delhi

SBI

STATE BANK OF INDIA

E-AUCTION SALE NOTICE

BRANCH OFFICE: HOME LOAN CENTRE EAST DELHI (15811), UNITY ONE MALL, FIRST FLOOR, CBD, SHAHDARA, DELHI-110032

NOTICE FOR E-AUCTION SALE ON 11.09.2026 FOR MOVABLE PROPERTY

E-Auction Sale Notice for Sale of Movable Assets under the Securitization and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 read with proviso to Rule 8(6) of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002. Notice is hereby given to the public in general and in particular to the Borrower(s) and Guarantor(s) that the below described movable property hypothecated /charged to the Secured Creditor, the physical possession of which has been taken by the Authorized Officer State Bank of India, the Secured Creditor, will be sold on "As is Where is", "As is What is" and "Whatever there is" on 11.09.2026, for recovery of bank due to the secured creditor as under:-

Interested bidder may deposit Pre-Bid EMD with BAANKNET before the close of e-Auction. Credit of Pre-Bid EMD shall be given to the bidder only after receipt of payment in BAANKNET's Bank Account and up-dation of such information in the e-auction website. This may take some time as per banking process and hence bidders, in their own interest, are advised to submit the pre-bid EMD amount well in advance to avoid any last minute problem.

Date / Time of E-Auction on 11.09.2026 for 6 Hours from 10:00 AM to 04:00 PM with unlimited extn. of 10 minute each.

For Vehicle Inspection Please Contact: Mr. Praveen Nagar - 9813314646 (M/s Suraj Legal Solutions Pvt. Ltd.)

S. No.	Name of the Borrower(s) / Guarantor(s)	Outstanding Dues for Recovery of which Property /ies is/ are being Sold	Vehicle Description	Reserve Price (Rs.) (below which property could not be sold) Earned Money (EMD) 10% of the Reserve Price Bid Increment Amount	Authorised Officer & Contact Person
1.	MR. ARPIT JAIN S/O MR. RAKESH KUMAR JAIN Car Loan A/c. No. 42009905758 H. No.1/4778, 1st Floor, Plot No.7, Gali No.8, Balbir Nagar, Shahdara East Delhi-110032	Rs.8,03,318.00 as on 25.10.2025 with further Interest and other Charges etc. thereon	Make & Model: CRETA 1.5 MPI MT S + SE Hyundai Motor India Ltd. Regn. No.: DL5CV1849 Regn. Date: 24.06.2023 Engine No.: G4FLPV656090 Chassis No.: MALPB812LPM521652 Colour: ABYSS Black Pearl	₹ 7,45,000.00 ₹ 74,500.00 ₹ 1,000.00 (Excluding GST As Applicable)	Chief Manager HLC East Delhi (15811), CBD, Shahdara, Delhi-110032 Mr. Praveen Nagar (Resolution Agent) 9813314646
2.	MR. PRADEEP KUMAR S/O BALESHWAR PRASAD Car Loan A/c. No. 40536447305 O-45, Near Satyawati Kuti, Vrindavan Garden Sahibabad, Pasosda Ghaziabad-201005.	Rs.5,61,078.00 as on 12.05.2023 with further Interest and other Charges etc. thereon	Make & Model: TRIBER RXT PETROL MT 1.0L ECE Regn. No.: UP14EX3883 Regn. Date: 22.11.2021 Engine No.: B4DA417E103134 Chassis No.: MEERBC006MA111896 Colour: ICEWOO WHITE	₹ 2,00,600.00 ₹ 20,000.00 ₹ 1,000.00 (Including 18% GST As Applicable)	Chief Manager HLC East Delhi (15811), CBD, Shahdara, Delhi-110032 Mr. Praveen Nagar (Resolution Agent) 9813314646

Last Date of EMD Deposit on or before 11.09.2026 upto 09:00 AM Account/ Wallet in which EMD to be remitted :- Bidder's own wallet Registered with BAANKNET on its e-auction site: <https://baanknet.com/eauction-psb/eproc-listing> by means of NEFT/RTGS. EMD of Reserve Price to be transferred by bidders by means of challan generated on his/her/their bidder account maintained with BAANKNET on its e-auction site: <https://baanknet.com/eauction-psb/eproc-listing> by means of NEFT from his/her/their bank. For any assistance, please call please call BAANKNET HELPDESK: +91 8291220220, support.BAANKNET@psballiance.com and/or Authorized Officer.

TERMS AND CONDITIONS OF THE E-AUCTION ARE AS UNDER:
(1) E-Auction is being held on "As is where is", "as is what is basis" and "whatever there is basis" and will be conducted "On Line". The auction will be conducted through the Bank's approved service provider BAANKNET at their web portal: <https://baanknet.com/eauction-psb/eproc-listing>
(2) Bank shall reserve the right to cancel/postpone the auction.
(3) The Vehicle are available for inspection during banking hours on 09.09.2026 from 11:00 AM to 4:00 PM, Contact: Mr. Praveen Nagar, Mobile: 9813314646 (Resolution Agent) and (Mr. Shashi, Mobile: 8979287749, SBI, Manager NPA)
(4) Successful bidder to pay GST as applicable on the successful bid amount, viz sale value.
(5) To the best of knowledge and information of the Authorized Officer there is no encumbrance on the property/ies. However the intending bidder should make their own independent inquiries regarding the encumbrances, title of the property/ies put on auction and claims/tights/dues/affecting the property prior to submitting their bid.
The e-Auction Advertisement does not constitute and will not be deemed to constitute any commitment or any representation of the Bank. The property is being sold with all the existing and future encumbrances whether known or unknown to the bank. The Authorized Officer shall not be responsible in any way for any third party claims/rights/ dues.
(6) The Earnest Money Deposit (EMD) of the successful bidder shall be retained towards part sale consideration and the EMD of the unsuccessful bidders shall be refunded. The Earnest Money Deposit shall not bear any Interest. The successful bidder shall have to deposit 25% of the sale price, immediately on acceptance of bid price by the Authorized Officer and the balance of the sale price on or before 15th day of the sale. Default in deposit of amount by the successful bidder would entail forfeiture of the whole money already deposited and property shall be put to the e-auction and the defaulting bidder shall have no claim/right in respect of property / amount.
(7) For detailed terms and conditions of the sale please refer to the link at the Bank's Service Provider's web portal: <https://baanknet.com/eauction-psb/eproc-listing> & e-auction website: <https://BAANKNET.com>
Date: 25.08.2026 Place: New Delhi Authorized Officer, State Bank of India, Home Loan Centre, East Delhi, Delhi

PROSPECT

India Health 2026 brings 300 healthcare brands together



The third edition of India Health 2026, India's flagship healthcare exhibition, opened at Bharat Mandapam, New Delhi, and brought together over 300 domestic and international brands and 8,000-plus healthcare and MedTech professionals.

The event backed India's ambition to become a global healthcare and manufacturing hub, with the sector's economy projected to reach ₹110.21 trillion by FY27. Dubai Health Authority's participation as an exhibitor spotlighted deepening India-UAE healthcare ties.

Various speakers from AMTZ, AHPI, ADMI and Informa spoke about the potential and challenges of patient-centric care, digital transformation, and India's growing medical-device manufacturing base.

The event also hosted the Global MedTech Conference and a parallel programme, "Driving Innovation to Shape the Future of Clinical Care," featuring 35-plus sessions and 80-plus speakers on AI and diagnostics. A newly launched B2B matchmaking app is enabling structured meetings between exhibitors and buyers as India strengthens its global healthcare and medical-tourism appeal.

(PNS)

Aadi Foam launches new mattress brand Sleeply

Aadi Foam has announced the launch of Sleeply, its new mattress brand, marking the company's entry into India's evolving sleep and mattress market.

Backed by over 36 years of experience in foam industry, Sleeply brings together Aadi Group's legacy of quality and consistency with a new-generation approach to comfort, innovation and the evolving needs of Indian consumers.

One of the key innovations associated with Sleeply is S5 Adaptive Zones™, a proprietary five-zone sleep support system developed to provide differentiated support across key areas of the body.

Speaking at the launch, Lokesh Jain, Managing Director, Aadi Foam & Founder, Sleeply, said, "Sleeply is the coming



together of 36 years of our experience with the aspirations of a new generation. We have combined our understanding of foam and manufacturing with a fresh approach to sleep, comfort and innovation. With USP such as our S5 Adaptive Zones™, we are focused on creating products that address different sleep needs while making quality and comfort accessible to more consumers. For us, Sleeply is not just a brand launch it is the beginning of a journey towards better comfort, better sleep and a better tomorrow."

PMFME Conclave 2026 recognises top States, banks

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The PMFME Conclave 2026 organised by the Ministry of Food Processing Industries (MoFPI) on 24-25 August 2026 at India Habitat Centre, New Delhi, concluded on Tuesday with a focus on sharing implementation experiences, strengthening stakeholder capacity and recognising excellence under the Pradhan Mantri Formalisation of Micro Food Processing Enterprises (PMFME) Scheme.

The two-day Conclave brought together 500+ stakeholders from across the country, including represen-

tatives from States and Union Territories, State Nodal Departments/Agencies, District Nodal Officers (DNOs), District Resource Persons (DRPs), banks and financial institutions, Ministries and Government organisations, technical institutions, industry bodies, incubation centres and PMFME beneficiaries.

The second day commenced with a PMFME Experience Sharing Session, where five States shared their best practices and implementation experiences. DNOs and DRPs also shared their field experiences, highlighting successful interventions and innovative approaches



Cabinet Minister of Food Processing Industries of India Chirag Paswan

adopted for effective implementation of the Scheme at the grassroots level.

This was followed by a session on "NIFTEMS - State-of-the-Art Facilities — Handholding PMFME Implementation", featuring

Harinder Singh Oberoi, Director, NIFTEM-Kundli and Professor V Palanimuthu, Director, NIFTEM-Thanjavur, which highlighted the role of technical institutions in providing technology, training and handholding support to

ICEYE sets up India operations in New Delhi

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

ICEYE, a global leader in sovereign intelligence from space, has formally established ICEYE India, with operations based in New Delhi, marking a significant expansion of its presence in one of the world's most important defence and space markets.

The announcement comes as India observes National Space Day, underscoring the growing strategic importance of space-based capabilities to national security, resilience and technological advancement. ICEYE India will focus initially on supporting Indian defence and intelligence customers with advanced Earth observation and intelligence capabilities designed to strengthen national security and resilience.

ICEYE plans to establish manufacturing capabilities in India, serving defence, surveillance and environmental monitoring requirements through local sourcing, Indian suppliers and engineering talent.

Rafal Modrzewski, CEO and Co-founder of ICEYE, said: "ICEYE India means real engineering and manufacturing capability on the ground. We're excited to build this together with the government and local partners and to support India as it strengthens its own sovereign intelligence capability."

Deeksha Vedantu focuses on future-ready learners

PIONEERS NEWS SERVICE
■ Bengaluru

With nearly three decades of experience in education and an alumni base of more than 85,000 students across Karnataka, Deeksha Vedantu is broadening its approach to learning to prepare students for a rapidly changing world shaped by technology and artificial intelligence.

The institution has traditionally built its reputation on academic rigour, conceptual clarity and preparation for board and compet-

itive examinations such as JEE and NEET. Its evolving approach seeks to complement this foundation with skills including critical thinking, problem-solving, creativity, adaptability and independent learning.

"Educational institutions have spent decades building a system that rewards the right answer. Artificial intelligence has made that the wrong ambition. The future graduate cannot simply know—they must think, question, and build," said Deeksha Vedantu founder Sridhar G.

Quantum Mutual Fund launches Flexi Cap fund

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

Quantum Mutual Fund has announced the launch of Quantum Flexi Cap Fund, an open-ended dynamic equity scheme investing across large cap, mid cap and small cap stocks. The New Fund Offer (NFO) opens on August 21 and closes on September 4. The scheme will reopen for continuous sale and repurchase from September 11.

The fund will follow a Growth at a Reasonable Price (GARP) investment approach and seek to identify structural changes in how value and profits are distributed across an industry's value chain, which Quantum refers to as "Profit Pool Shifts".

According to the fund

house, these shifts can be driven by disruption, consolidation, changing consumer preferences or regulatory developments. The investment team will seek to identify companies positioned to benefit from such changes and allocate across market capitalisations based on growth opportunities and relative valuations.

Commenting on the launch, Chirag Mehta, CIO & Fund Manager, said: "The Fund is designed to identify such structural shifts through fundamental research and invest in high-quality businesses available at reasonable valuations. Our objective is to build a diversified portfolio that can compound wealth over the long term philosophy."

Sarbananda Sonowal launches NSB website, receives annual reports at Sagar Samvad

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The National Shipping Board (NSB) held its first 'Sagar Samvad' on Tuesday, using the day-long dialogue to press for a five-point roadmap including to add 100 vessels to India's foreign-dependent merchant fleet over the next five years, as expressed by the Union Minister of Ports, Shipping & Waterways (MoPSW), Sarbananda Sonowal during his speech.

The event, themed "Charting the Roadmap Towards Maritime India Vision 2030 and Maritime Amrit Kaal Vision 2047," was held at the Civil Services Officers Institute on Vinay Marg and drew senior officials, shipowners, financiers and young cadets from India's maritime training institutes. Sagar Samvad, which means "ocean dialogue," carries the board's motto as its theme line: "Wisdom in the Ocean, Progress in the Nation."

The inaugural edition of Sagar Samvad was chaired by Union Minister Sarbananda Sonowal, who launched the board's first official website. NSB Chairperson Sameer Kumar Khare used the session to submit the board's annual report for 2025-26, subcommittee reports containing the policy advice for the Government to Sonowal, outlining the board's work since its reconstitution in May 2025.

"Under the dynamic leadership of Prime Minister



Narendra Modi ji, under the re-enacted Merchant Shipping Act, 2025, and the new National Shipping Board Rules, the mandate has been renewed and strengthened. That is exactly why a platform like 'Sagar Samvad' matters — bringing policymakers, industry captains, technocrats and civil society into one room to argue, test ideas and build intellectual consensus in the open as per the highest tradition of a thriving democracy like India. That consensus, and nothing else, is what will carry us to an Atmanirbhar Shipping Bharat by 2047," Sonowal added.

Later in the day, a session on "Maritime Labour Force— Opportunities and Challenges" was chaired by Union Minister of Labour & Employment and Youth Affairs & Sports, Mansukh Mandaviya.

Speaking on the session, Union Minister Mansukh Mandaviya said, "India's maritime sector has the

potential to become a major engine of employment for our young workforce and position India as the world's leading supplier of skilled seafarers.

Mandaviya emphasised that India must leverage the expanding global demand for skilled maritime professionals to create high-quality employment opportunities for its growing youth population.

The Union Minister of State for Ports, Shipping and Waterways, Shantanu Thakur, presided over a panel discussion titled "Augmentation of Indian Tonnage: Opportunities and Challenges." Also in attendance was Vijay Kumar, Secretary of the Ministry of Ports, Shipping and Waterways.

Sonowal also acknowledged the success of the Container Manufacturing Assistance Scheme, worth ₹10,000 crore, with global shipping major Maersk now ordering containers built on Indian soil.

CBI arrests 2 offenders in separate bank fraud cases



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The CBI has arrested two proclaimed offenders who had allegedly been evading trial proceedings for 17 years and four years, respectively, in two separate bank fraud cases, officials said on Tuesday.

The accused, identified as Jitendra Kumar and Pooja Pahwa, were arrested after sustained efforts and intelligence gathering by the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI), the agency's spokesperson said in a statement.

Kumar was allegedly involved in a home loan default dating back to 2002-03, in which the loan was obtained using fake and forged salary certificates, causing a loss of Rs 65.90 lakh to GIC Housing Finance Limited.

"The account was declared NPA in 2012," the statement said. Pahwa was chargesheeted along with five others in 2017. A supplementary chargesheet was later filed against four bank officials for allegedly conspiring with the beneficiary company and individuals.

Pahwa, who was declared a proclaimed offender in 2023, was apprehended from Ludhiana in Punjab on August 4 following "continuous intelligence gathering and execution of targeted efforts by the CBI".

She is currently in judicial custody, it said.

not appear before the court since 2009.

Kumar was declared a proclaimed offender in January 2013 and arrested from Dwarka Mor in New Delhi on Tuesday.

In the second case, Pahwa was allegedly involved in the diversion and misappropriation of a cash credit facility availed based on false and forged documents, causing a loss of Rs 10.16 crore to Indian Overseas Bank.

"The account was declared NPA in 2012," the statement said. Pahwa was chargesheeted along with five others in 2017. A supplementary chargesheet was later filed against four bank officials for allegedly conspiring with the beneficiary company and individuals.

Pahwa, who was declared a proclaimed offender in 2023, was apprehended from Ludhiana in Punjab on August 4 following "continuous intelligence gathering and execution of targeted efforts by the CBI".

She is currently in judicial custody, it said.

NBCC organises 20th edition of SAMVAAD

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

NBCC (India) Limited successfully organised the 20th edition of SAMVAAD at the Convention Centre, East Kidwai Nagar, New Delhi. The two-day programme included discussions on project execution, business development, financial performance, technology adoption, human resources management and organisational growth.

The programme was attended by KP Mahadevaswamy, Chairman and Managing Director, NBCC, Suman Kumar, Director (Commercial), Anjeev Kumar Jain, Director (Finance), Ritu Pande, Chief Vigilance Officer (CVO), senior management, RBG/SBG heads, project heads, and employees.

The first day featured a presentation on "Cyber Hygiene" by Anish Prashad, IPS officer of the 2003 batch



from the Tripura cadre, focusing on cyber security awareness, responsible digital practices and digital fraud prevention. This was followed by a presentation by Kapil Deo Narayan, Chief Technical Examiner (CTE), Central Vigilance Commission (CVC), providing insights into technical examination, vigilance, quality-related aspects of major Government construction projects.

Addressing the gathering, KP Mahadevaswamy, CMD, NBCC, emphasised working towards the collective vision of becoming a Maharatna company.

DAILY SUDOKU

DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★☆☆☆

HOW TO SOLVE IT

Sudoku is a logic puzzle where you fill a 9x9 grid so that numbers 1 to 9 appear once in every row, column, and 3x3 box, using elimination and logical deduction—no maths involved.

SOLUTION (25.8.26)

DOUBLE CROSSWORD

WEDNESDAY | AUGUST 26, 2026

ACROSS

DOWN

SOLUTION (25.8.26)

ACROSS

DOWN

BRIEFLY

FIDE-rated Rapid Chess title to bring 1,000 players together



A FIDE-rated Rapid Chess tournament, featuring up to a 1000 players, will take place here on Wednesday as the city gears up to host the world's top chess stars for Season 4 of the Tech Mahindra Global Chess League (GCL) next month. The tournament at the Koramangala Indoor Stadium will carry a prize purse of ₹4 lakh and offer participants an opportunity to experience the build-up to the GCL, which will be held in Bengaluru from September 5 to 13. "The Road to GCL is about bringing the spirit of the Global Chess League closer to the people who make chess what it is, the players, fans, and communities who continue to grow the game," GCL Commissioner Gourav Rakshit said. "Bringing 1,000 players together for a FIDE-rated tournament in Bengaluru is a great way to build momentum for Season 4 and celebrate the depth of chess talent in the city. "We hope this experience offers participants not just the opportunity to compete, but also a chance to feel part of the larger GCL journey and experience world-class chess up close," he added. (PTI)

Pratitee, Mayank inch closer to winning titles in Asian junior chess



Top seeds Pratitee Bordoloi and Mayank Chakraborty moved a step closer to the Asian Junior Classical Chess Championship crowns with wins in the eighth and penultimate round here on Tuesday. Pratitee scored a crucial victory over FM (FIDE Master) Prishita Gupta to take her tally to an impressive 7/8 and extend her lead to a full point. Her nearest rival, WCM (Woman Candidate Master) Shohradova Leyla of Turkmenistan, was held to a draw by WCM Dakshita Kumawat and moved to 6 points. WFM (Woman FIDE Master) Mariya Kholyavko of Kazakhstan and WCM Sravyasree Bheemarasetty registered important victories to also reach 6 points. In the Open Championship, Mayank Chakraborty strengthened his grip on the title by defeating Daksh Goyal to move to 7/8. His nearest challenger, IM (International Master) Artem Pingin of Russia, scored an important victory over IM Vignesh Advaita Vemula to reach 6.5 points. FM Sharnathi Viresh was held to a draw by IM Apoorv Kamble and moved to 6 points, while FM Madhvendra Pratap Sharma defeated CM (Candidate Master) Ahmet Gubatayev of Turkmenistan to also reach 6 points. With one round remaining, Mayank holds a half-point advantage over Pingin, setting up an exciting finish to the Open Championship. Pratitee, meanwhile, holds a one-point cushion over her nearest challengers as both title races head into the decisive final round. (PTI)

PRAGGNANANDHAA SAILS INTO FINALS OF GRAND CHESS TOUR

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ St Louis (USA)

Indian Grandmaster R Praggnanandhaa cruised into the finals of the Grand Chess Tour's last leg after clinching a crushing 19-9 win over Germany's Vincent Keymer here. Pragnanandhaa will take on pre-event favourite and defending champion Fabiano Caruana of the USA States in the event finale. Having won the second Classical game, the Indian enjoyed a huge lead of six points coming into the final day on which games of shorter duration were played. He defeated Keymer in



back-to-back rapid encounters to nearly seal his spot in the finals taking an unassailable 17-3 lead before another victory in the first game of blitz took his points tally to 19. As per rules, all the games have to be played and Keymer fought his way back by winning the last three blitz games even though the scoreline was beyond repairs for him. Caruana is not known to be a power in faster version of the game but on Monday he proved that he could prove that assessment wrong.

Indian hockey not handling transition well, say former stars

MONA PARTHSARATHI
■ Amstelveen

The Indian men's hockey team was not expected to end its 51-year-old World Cup title drought but its failure to even reach the semi-finals has exposed some long-standing frailties, including lack of intent to carry out a tough transition. The 3-5 defeat to Argentina, which ended India's semifinal hopes, exposed weaknesses that have repeatedly surfaced since the Paris Olympics. Two-time Olympic bronze medallist goalkeeper PR Sreejesh is aghast as to how none of the talented juniors coming through the system have been given exposure

with less than two years left for the Los Angeles Olympics. "Who is there to take the reins when seniors retire? Have we developed a second string? LA Olympics is just two years away and we will play around 30 quality international matches before that. Is that enough to prepare a player for the Olympics? No," a fuming Sreejesh said while talking to PTL. "The 2026 World Cup team is still revolving around the same core group of players while promising juniors like Manmeet Singh, who was the top scorer at the Junior World Cup with six goals, Amir Ali, Roshan Kujur, Shardanand Tiwari, Talem Priyabarta, Rohit, and Arshdeep Singh were simply



overlooked," he added. The 1980 Moscow Olympics gold medal winning captain V Baskaran was scathing about India's attacking output and the failure to integrate youngsters. "The transition from junior to senior has not taken place properly. Germany and the Netherlands have had a smooth transition. Look at the Netherlands team from the Paris Olympics and the

Pakistan hockey needs fresh blood after disappointing WC: Ex-players

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Karachi

Former Pakistan hockey players have lamented the team's dismal performance at the ongoing World Cup in the Netherlands and Belgium, calling for an injection of fresh blood to revive the country's once-glorious hockey tradition. They also believe that cricket's overwhelming popularity in Pakistan is, to some extent, a consequence of hockey's steep decline, which has gradually eroded the sport's following in country. Despite being the most



successful team in WC history with four titles, Pakistan have endured a 32-year barren spell since their last triumph in 1994. Their struggles continued at ongoing tourna-

ment, where they were eliminated from title race and will now face South Africa in the classification match for 11th place. The Pakistan Hockey Federation (PHF) recently announced plans to launch a hockey league and promote the sport in schools and other educational institutions. However, former players believe the federation's immediate priority should be preparing the national team for the Asian Games in Japan next month. They argue that a strong performance at the Asian Games would be crucial to restoring confidence in Pakistan hockey and laying the foundation for its revival. "This league and all is fine in the long run but Pakistan hockey needs an injection which will only come if we do well in Asian Games against India, Malaysia, Japan, China, Korea," said former Olympian Wasim Feroze. He cautioned that unless Pakistan hockey began winning matches and producing positive results, youngsters would gradually lose interest in the sport, which was already a major concern for hockey in the country.

Ahmedabad to host Commonwealth cue sports title

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Bengaluru

As one of the world's premier destinations for cue sports, India will host the second Commonwealth Cue Sports Championships from October 7-10 at the Veer Savarkar Sports Complex in Ahmedabad. The four-day event will see cueists from nearly 46 countries compete across five disciplines - billiards, snooker, heyball, 10-ball pool and blackball -- in both categories (men and women), stated a release from Billiards and Snooker Federation of India on Tuesday. The championships will feature 16 players in each category in four disciplines, while billiards, which has been included in the programme this year, will be an eight-player draw in each section. The championships will be held under the aegis of the World Confederation of Billiards Sports (WCBS) and the Billiards and Snooker



Federation of India (BSFI), and organised by Apex Sports. "Ahmedabad is becoming an increasingly important city on the international sporting map, and hosting the Commonwealth Cue Sports Championships here is a significant opportunity for our sport and for India," said Ishaun Singh, president of

the World Pool Association (WPA). "With the city now preparing to host the 2030 Commonwealth Games, this event gives us an opportunity to build a strong connection with the sporting community and audiences here. India has an extraordinary history in cue sports, and from everything we have seen through our recent events," the world body chief added. "This is the second of the three big-ticket events we will be hosting as part of BSFI's centenary celebrations," said S Balasubramaniam, president of the BSFI. The federation hosted the heyball World Championships, the highest-ever cue sports prize money event in the country, earlier this month in Pune. It would also host the IBSF World Snooker Championships in Indore from November 12-21. The BSFI named the squad for the Ahmedabad championships on Tuesday. Thirteen cueists (six men and seven women) will represent the country at the four-day event.



Save women's Hockey India League, India's WC hockey stars appeal

MONA PARTHSARATHI
■ Amstelveen

India's women hockey players have made an emotional appeal to save the Women's Hockey India League, saying the tournament has played a crucial role in building the confidence of a young team that is on the verge of its best-ever World Cup finish since 1974. With 11 World Cup debutants in the squad, India have lost just one match against Olympic champions the Netherlands while holding Olympic silver medallists China to a 2-2 draw in their opening game. India were knocked out of semifinal contention after a goalless draw against Australia and will now play for fifth and sixth place, which would still be their best World Cup finish in 52 years. The players believe the Women's HIL has been a major factor behind their progress and fear that its discontinuation could hurt the next generation of

Indian talent. "I think we have done our best to inspire girls in India to hold a hockey stick. People prefer their kids to play individual sports, but this should give them hope," veteran midfielder Neha, who led Odisha Warriors to the maiden HIL title in 2024-25, told PTL. "In the last two years, HIL for women has benefited us a lot. Junior and senior Nationals do not have this level of competition. Women's HIL has given us players like Baljeet, Sakshi and Rutuja, who are part of this World Cup team. For upcoming players also, we need this league. It should not be discontinued." The appeal comes as the revived women's HIL faces serious financial challenges, including high operational costs, low broadcast and ticket revenues, delayed player payments and limited sponsorship interest. India's captain Salima Tete also stressed the league's role in widening the national talent pool. (PTI)

Tottenham signs Savinho from Manchester City

STEVE DOUGLAS
■ London

Tottenham took its summer spending to more than \$400 million by signing Brazil winger Savinho from Manchester City on Tuesday in a deal worth 85 million pounds (\$115 million). During this transfer window, Spurs have already brought in Italy midfielder Sandro Tonali from Newcastle for a reported club-record fee of 100 million pounds (\$133 million), days after purchasing another midfielder in Mateus Fernandes from West Ham for 85 million pounds (then \$113 million). The summer refresh under Roberto De Zerbi - setting out on his first full season in charge of Tottenham - now



includes the 22-year-old Savinho, who joined City in 2024 for 40 million euros (\$43.6 million) from sister club Troyes but hasn't lived up to expectations. He scored two goals in 53 Premier League appearances

and didn't make Brazil's squad for this year's World Cup. Referring to a transfer saga that has lasted most of this summer, Savinho said in a Tottenham statement: "It's taken a while but I'm very happy to be here.

"It's a wonderful opportunity at a brilliant club with one of the best managers in the world. As soon as I spoke to the head coach, I knew I had to come. He told me he wants to help me reach the highest level, and I believe we can do that together, as a team." De Zerbi hailed Savinho's "energy, imagination and quality," saying: "He has the courage to attack defenders and the ability to change a game with his creativity." Tottenham began the Premier League season by fielding a much-changed starting lineup, containing Tonali and fellow new signings Jan Paul van Hecke, Marco Senesi and Andy Robertson, in a 3-0 loss at Brentford. (AP)

Excluded 5 in tennis not part of AITA list, don't meet criteria: SIA official

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The five tennis players excluded from the country's Asian Games squad did not feature in the long list sent to the IOA by the All India Tennis Association (AITA), a Sports Authority of India (SAI) source said on Tuesday, justifying the omission on the basis of their lower-than-prescribed international rankings. Manas Dhamne (men's singles), Vaishnavi Adkar (women's singles), Sahaja Yamalapalli (women's singles), Vaidehee Chaudhari (women's doubles) and Prarthana Thombare (women's doubles) were not included in the seven-



member Indian squad as they did not meet the criteria of being inside the top-8 of continental standings. "Their names were not received by Sports Ministry in the final list shared by the IOA (Indian Olympic Association). In fact their names were not there in the long list sent by

AITA to IOA," the source said. Their exclusion, the source said, is justified as their recent performances too did not reflect medal probability or potential for effective participation in the showpiece. The Ministry's selection mandate required individual athletes to be among top six in Asia for singles events and be ranked within the top eight in Asia for doubles over a 12-month evaluation window. This criteria was unveiled by the Sports Ministry in September last year. Their omission was criticised by Rohan Bopanna, who said "a committee that never stood where they stood has decided their fate on paper, before a ball is struck."

Mourinho says Vinicius Junior unfairly targeted but wants him to manage his emotions better

TALES AZZONI
■ Madrid

Jose Mourinho, once known for his fiery personality and frequent touchline outbursts, wants to help Vinicius Junior control his emotions better. Mourinho, looking much calmer at the start of his second stint as Real Madrid coach, said Tuesday that he thinks Vinicius is being unfairly targeted, but the star forward can do better when reacting to provocations. The Brazilian was involved in several incidents with opposing fans and players in the team's opening Spanish league match at Espanyol on Saturday. Madrid hosts Real Sociedad for its second

match on Wednesday. "There is on the field and off the field," Mourinho said. "The reaction to fans and insults, obviously if they are not racist or homophobic insults, but the typical insults by fans, then I think he can control it better. His relationship with the opposing fans, I think he can do better. In the game, when it comes to the fouls and the accumulation of frustration that he feels, that's the responsibility of the referees, or the judges, as I like to call them, in terms of their responsibility to protect the players and the game." Mourinho said it's harder to help Vinicius when it comes to the in-game inci-



dents, but when it's about his relationship with the opposing fans, then "it's some-

thing that we can work on." Last year, Mourinho was criticized for attacking Vinicius'

character after the player accused an opponent of racially insulting him during

a Champions League match against Benfica. The coach in charge of Benfica at the time suggested that the Brazil forward incited opposing players with his celebrations after scoring. "When I was Benfica's coach, I was only interested about Benfica," Mourinho said Tuesday. The veteran Portuguese coach said it's become obvious the difference in the treatment on the field toward Vinicius and toward other players. "It's gone into a spiral in which the opponents know what they can do and what they can't do," he said. "If the players can provoke and pressure Vini, either physical-

ly or with words, if the yellow card is only shown after 10 fouls, if there can be violence, then it's a type of treatment that I don't like." Mourinho, returning to Madrid after a stint at the club from 2010 to 2013, said he would likely be quickly sent off if he was in Vinicius' shoes in some of the situations that he faces. The coach noted, though, that his own behavior has changed significantly over the years and is not as fiery as he once was. "I'm think I'm calmer," Mourinho said. "And it's not just now, I've been like that over the last few years. I feel calmer, with more control of my emotions." (AP)

Dinusha, Sooriyabandara lead SL resistance against India in 2nd Test

G UNNIKRISHNAN
■ Colombo

Indian bowlers failed to break through the Sri Lankan resistance spearheaded by Sonal Dinusha and Pasindu Sooriyabandara in the company of late order batters as the home side finished day three of the second Test on 265 for eight here on Tuesday.

Dinusha (85 batting) and Lahiru Kumara (8 batting) were at the crease when stumps were drawn early because of rain and bad light. Sri Lanka still need 38 runs to avoid the follow-on after India amassed 503 for nine in their first innings.

Once the hosts resumed from the tea score of 216 for

seven, they were staring at an earlier end to the innings.

But Dinusha notched up his third 50-plus score in as many innings in this series to keep the Indians at bay across two sessions. A diminutive left-hander, Dinusha displayed towering spirit and technical nous to counter the Indians. Prasidh tested him with lifters and toe-crushers while spinners - Manav Suthar, Ravindra Jadeja and Saransh Jain - teased his awareness of lines.

The 25-year-old, however, came out of those tough interrogation spaces with flying colours, leaving the Indians a frustrated lot for 201 minutes.

However, Dinusha, who fetched his fifty in 84 balls, had two equally stone-minded

companions - Keshara Nuwantha and Lahiru Kumara.

With Nuwantha, he added 57 runs for the eighth wicket and the former played out 74 balls, and then added 35 runs for the ongoing ninth wicket with Kumara, who consumed 50 balls in 65 minutes.

The Indians will be a massively disappointed lot to see an old failing against tail-end batters resurfacing at a very inopportune moment at the SSC ground. But before they hit the roadblock, the Indians appeared to have primed to put an early end to Sri Lankan innings, reducing them to 216 for seven at tea.

In the pre-lunch session, Sri Lanka were competitive despite losing two wickets as



they had added 122 runs.

But in the middle passage, the visiting bowlers took command of the proceedings, scalping four wickets and conceded just 86 runs.

India inflicted an early jolt on Sri Lanka as left-arm spinner

batters. But body blow was the dismissal of Sooriyabandara (80), who batted with a rare mix of patience and elegance.

Jadeja, who made only a cameo appearance in the opening session of the day, bowled one close to Sooriyabandara's body, and the batter's effort to guide the ball down point saw his stumps getting rearranged.

Two runs later, Mohammad Siraj accounted for Niroshan Dickwella with a rather innocuous down the leg delivery, which the Lankan batter edged to Dhruv Jurel.

Before their late evening fight back, Sri Lanka had their moments in the first session too, courtesy a good 87-run alliance for the third wicket

between Sooriyabandara and Kamindu Mendis.

Starting from eight for two, the home side showed better spirit in the opening passage of the day, which was also spiced up by verbal exchanges between Sarfaraz Khan, substituting for Rishabh Pant, Siraj and the Lankan batters.

Before the Lankans gained some foothold, India began the day brightly, dismissing overnight batter Kamil Mishara (19). Mishara failed to deal with a viciously rising delivery from Prasidh, fending it to stumper Jurel.

But Sooriyabandara and Mendis thwarted Indians' hopes of making further inroads into the Lankan top order for nearly two hours.

They tackled the bowlers with little nerves, and hardly allowed two spinners - Suthar and debutant Jain to settle down. The off-spinner Jain procured some bounce and turn but Lankan duo handled that rather comfortably.

Sooriyabandara, who was playing his second Test, was the lead act of that third wicket alliance. The elegant right-hander reached his maiden Test fifty in 76 balls. Mendis, smashed Suthar for a six over mid-wicket to announce his intentions. But Prasidh, who bowled two lively spells, broke blooming alliance with another snorter aimed at the throat of Mendis, which he pulled straight into the hands of Jadeja at mid-wicket. (PTI)

Muralitharan, Daniel Vettori helped improve my bowling: Zeeshan Ansari



SANSKRITI GAUBA
■ New Delhi

His long wait for a comeback in red-ball cricket was fuelled by lessons picked up from legendary spinners Muttiah Muralitharan and Daniel Vettori during a stint with Sunrisers Hyderabad in the IPL, says legspinner Zeeshan Ansari. The UP player, who was a member of India's U-19 World Cup 2016 side alongside the likes of Ishan Kishan, Rishabh Pant, and Washington Sundar, saw his career getting a boost when SRH roped him in their squad during IPL 2025.

Ansari followed it up with a strong comeback for Uttar Pradesh in the Vijay Hazare Trophy, nearly five years after his last Ranji Trophy appearance for the state in 2020. He was also picked in the India 'A' side for their two unofficial Tests in Sri Lanka.

"When I was in SRH, I benefited a lot from Muttiah Muralitharan and Daniel Vettori. They told me a lot of things about bowling that I did not know. Whatever I learnt from them has helped me a lot. If I keep doing the same things, my graph will improve," Ansari said. The 26-year-old has also

been benefiting from the guidance of former India spinner Piyush Chawla during UP T20 League. "I have spoken to Chawla twice in the UP T20. He told me that I am bowling really well and gave me some advice. I am learning as much as I can from them. They are helping me a lot," Ansari said.

Ansari has carried his form into the UP T20 League, where he is the leading wicket-taker with 14 wickets from six matches. His team Meerut Mavericks have also been unbeaten, winning all six games so far.

"The team is in good mood right now. We have won six out of six matches, so everyone is happy. I want to go and play the Duleep Trophy after this match. So, this will be my last match here. I want to do well in Duleep Trophy," he said.

He also praised captain Rinku Singh for ability to connect with the players.

"The best thing about him is that he talks to all the players. Even when you are on the ground, he is able to connect with you and understand you. He asks you whether you should bowl or not. That makes him really special," Ansari said. (PTI)

Prasidh has developed into world-class bowler: Morne Morkel

G UNNIKRISHNAN
■ Colombo

India bowling coach Morne Morkel showered encomium on pacer Prasidh Krishna for ignoring "outside voices" to work hard on his game, developing into a "world class bowler."

Prasidh took three wickets (3/47) in an intense 14-over spell across the day to lead India's bowling unit against Sri Lanka on the third day of the second Test here on Tuesday. "It (the spell) showed the character of Prasidh. He has the media on his back, the commentators on his back, to fight through that...and his bowling at the moment is very impressive," Morkel began the post-day press meet.

Morkel was delighted to



see Prasidh operating calmly through a zillion distracting voices. "It is about quieting those voices and just playing cricket. As a team, we always knew about his potential. As soon as you get into this

"But Prasidh, for me, the biggest change is just to let go of all those thoughts, all those comments that are made on him...he is just enjoying his cricket." The South African was delighted to see the single minded efforts of the Karnataka pacer yielding some wonderful results.

"He is an extremely hard worker, he is a guy that will do a lot of homework, going into games, doing a lot of research about opposition. So for him, he is a massive student of the game.

"It is just great to see him grow and develop into a world class bowler. I think for India, in all formats, he has the potential and talent to play for a very long time," he said.

Morkel then proceeded to detail the ingredients that

make Prasidh a successful bowler at the highest level.

"Look, a lot of the time it is a captain and coach's decision trying to create something if there is not much on the ball or not much happening off the surface. I think as a world class bowler, it is very important to always try and create something.

"Prasidh has got that extra pace and bounce, so we are going to use him in certain phases where it might be risky but we might get the reward as well." But several times, Prasidh has leaked runs while fitting into that battering ram role the team has been trying to assign to him.

For Morkel, it was nothing but a passable occupational hazard. "There were a lot of times, I think back in England

(2025), where we had to put our hand up because we were asking the boy to do a certain job. Although the results sometimes might not go his way, the whole team is behind him.

"That is all that matters is how we sort of get around him when we move away and sit in a hotel to talk through those things and answer the questions that he might have and we give him clarity and confidence going into that.

"It is sometimes a tough job, a donkey job. But I think he has done that very well for us in the last two or three years. His game has also grown now and he can hit that fuller length much more consistently, which is great to see," he detailed.

Can't write them off but NZ tour will be tough: Dravid on India's WTC chances

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Mumbai

Former head coach Rahul Dravid says India have slightly "fallen behind" in the race to qualify for the World Test Championships (WTC) final and even though the performance in Sri Lanka right now is encouraging, it would not be easy for the team to put it past New Zealand during an upcoming series.

Currently placed fifth in the points table, two-time finalists India are locked in an uphill battle to win the majority of their remaining matches in the World Test Championship 2025-2027 and move up.

With top two teams slated to play in the final next year, India, who are ranked fifth behind Bangladesh, will play

two away Tests in New Zealand before taking on Australia in a five-Test series at home from January 2027. India will also play five ODIs and as many T20Is against the Kiwis.

"I'm hoping they do. It'll be a great run if India can qualify for the WTC final from here," Dravid, a team owner in European T20 Premier League (ETPL), told 'JioStar' when asked if India would be able to make the summit clash from here.

"They've fallen behind a little bit, but the kind of quality that the Indian team has, you're not going to write them off at any stage. They started off well against Sri Lanka, so that's a good first step," he said.

India lead the two-match series against Sri Lanka 1-0 and



have the upperhand in the second Test following a solid batting performance.

Talking about New Zealand tour in October, Dravid said the experience of retired seniors such as Virat Kohli and Cheteshwar Pujara would be missed in the two Tests.

"Hopefully, they can keep the guys fit and not have a lot of injuries over the next few months. We're missing the experience of Virat (Kohli) and Rohit (Sharma), Ajinkya Rahane and (Cheteshwar) Pujara, these kinds of guys who've probably been there the last time India went. So that will be an interesting series as well," Dravid added.

The former India captain said even the visiting Australian team would have players desperate to do well in the Border-Gavaskar Trophy come January.

"Australia will be really exciting. A lot of their players will be very keen to do well in India. That's a generation of truly great Australian players, a great Australian team that has not won in India. So they'll

be keen to do that," he said.

Dravid also called for a patient approach towards 15-year-old batting talent Vaibhav Sooryavanshi, saying he would need a "couple of seasons of red-ball cricket" to find his feet in the longest format. "With Vaibhav, you've got to be patient. He's only 15-years-old, and from what I've seen of the kid, I have no doubt that given the opportunity to practice and play domestic cricket and a couple of seasons of red-ball cricket, he will be able to hold his own in Test match team," he said.

Dravid said it would be challenging to find space for domestic cricket in Sooryavanshi's calendar, which will be quite packed because of white-ball duties with national team.

Pakistan sweats over Babar Azam's injury

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Karachi

Pakistan is sweating over the availability of skipper Babar Azam for the second Test against England at Lord's beginning on Thursday. A source close to team said on Tuesday that Babar was suffering from a finger injury, and the swelling made it difficult for him to grip the bat properly. Babar first got hit on the fingers while batting in the second Test against the West Indies before the tour to England.

His injury worsened when he decided to bat a few overs in a three-day practice game against the Counties XI in Kent, where he retired after being hit again on the same finger. He missed the opening Test at Leeds, which Pakistan



lost by an innings and 103 runs inside three days because of the injury, and Salman Ali Agha led the side. "The team management will see if Babar is comfortable batting in the nets tomorrow, but it is a sort of injury where the final decision must come from the player himself," the source said.

The Pakistan team management is considering playing both their spinners, Ali Usman

and Sajid Khan, in the Lord's Test, as the feeling is the pitch will be sluggish and could assist the slow bowlers. With Pakistan's three-pronged pace attack of Muhammad Abbas, Khurrrum Shehzad, and Muhammad Ali delivering a below-par performance in the first Test, the source said Babar and head coach Sarfaraz Ahmed are inclined to rely on the spinners to level the series.

Ali Usman took 5 for 98 with his left-arm spin in England's only innings in the Leeds Test, while Sajid grabbed eight wickets when Pakistan beat West Indies to level the two-match series 1-1.

All of Pakistan's Test wins from December 2023 onwards have come through their spinners, whether Noman Ali, Sajid, or Usman.

We have developed winning culture, hungry for more: Harmanpreet

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Indian women cricketers are "hungry for more" after a string of impressive victories, with captain Harmanpreet Kaur saying a winning culture is taking shape as they head into the Asia Cup in the UAE and Asian Games in Japan. Fresh from winning the first-ever women's Test match at Lord's by defeating England last month, India will now turn their attention to the UAE Asia Cup T20, where they are record seven-time champions, before embarking on their title defence at the Asian Games in Japan.

"We of course expect to win. Our team has been playing very good cricket," the

India skipper, who guided India to a historic Test win against England at the iconic Lord's recently, told Sony Sports. "The last 4-5 years has been good and where we have played good cricket, dominating cricket, have defeated big teams and won series also.

The Kaur-led side had sealed a huge 270-run win over England at Lord's, marking India's second-highest win by margin of runs in Women's Tests, the fourth biggest overall.

"Now, we are coming after the win at Lord's and have also won many games on the trot, so the team has already tasted success and will be hungry for more." In the upcoming Asia Cup, beginning Friday, India



share Group A with arch-rivals Pakistan in the eight-team tournament. After losing the last edition to Sri Lanka, India will look to reclaim the trophy, riding high on their recent Lord's triumph.

"The best thing is, everybody in the team talks about how to win a match, how to win tournaments. So when

lenge is when you have the 'good team' tag, playing for those expectations is in itself a very big challenge because we know we dominate Asian cricket and it's very important to play every match with that domination," she opined.

On the hype surrounding India-Pakistan clashes, Harmanpreet said the pressure is on another level, something players can genuinely feel despite being accustomed to high-intensity competitive cricket. "No doubt it's a high-pressure game and as a player you need to deal with multiple things. We keep playing international cricket but the amount of pressure in a India vs Pakistan match, that kind of pressure you don't feel anywhere else.

English cricket and its drinking problem: Another nightclub incident brings shame on men's team

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■ London

It was a telling remark, especially when revisited two months later. "I probably won't be real happy and smiley," then-England cricket captain Ben Stokes told reporters after beating New Zealand in a hard-fought test match at Lord's in June, "until I get up there and share a proper beer with the boys."

After all, having a post-match drink with teammates and sometimes rivals in the

dressings room is a cricketing tradition as old as time.

The off-field conduct and drinking habits of England's men's squad are back under scrutiny this week after another nightclub incident involving one of its players.

This time it was Brydon Carse, a 31-year-old fast bowler and one of the team's success stories in recent years. The images of him - outside a club in the early hours of Sunday in hand-cuffs and surrounded by police officers - were hard to



ignore, especially as the saga came days after a plea by newly appointed England captain Joe Root.

"Ultimately you're grown adults," said Root, speaking after England's leadership opted to scrap a midnight curfew that had been imposed on the men's team following a string of controversial late-night incidents.

"You know what it takes to play for England, you know what your responsibilities are off the field, and we need to make sure we don't find

ourselves with any little situations off the field."

And so, with England's Cricket Regulator getting down to work investigating another off-the-field issue, it's back to square one.

In this age of sports science and ultra-professionalism, there are wider questions over whether cricketers should have a beer after a match. Or do players just need to be a bit smarter?

"Just have some kind of brain cells amongst you, seeing what's just gone on,"

former England captain Alastair Cook said on the Stick to Cricket podcast released Tuesday. "Surely someone says either don't go to that place, or at 12 a.m. or 1 a.m. say, 'Let's go and find ourselves somewhere quieter if we want to carry on.'"

Here's a look at the late-night incidents that have brought shame on English cricket: Before going to Australia for what proved a humiliating Ashes series, England traveled to New Zealand in October for a

white-ball tour. A day before the third and final one-day international, team captain Harry Brook was hit by a bouncer after being denied entry to a club in Wellington, with teammates Jacob Bethell and Josh Tongue also present on the night out.

Brook was fined about 30,000 pounds (\$40,300) at the time and given a final warning for his future conduct - sanctions not made public until months later, after the Ashes series that England lost 4-1. (AP)